

Group Project: Redesigning the Group Travel Planning Experience

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1 INTRODUCTION

This group project is inspired by the fact that so many people love to travel with friends and family, but the coordination aspect is lacking on current travel sites. Group travel is such a unique experience (both good and bad), but there are so many factors that go into it: Deciding on a destination, coordinating schedules, booking hotels, transportation, and flights, splitting costs, and keeping everyone informed as plans shift around requires a great deal of coordination. When it works, everyone is happy and the trip becomes that much more amazing. However, when it breaks down, it can be a nightmare that ruins the trip before it even starts.

The task this project investigates is **planning a group trip**: the full life cycle from initial idea to a finalized, shared itinerary. This encompasses selecting a destination, choosing and booking accommodations and activities, managing shared costs, and keeping all participants aligned as plans inevitably evolve. This task is relevant to virtually any adult who has traveled with more than one other person.

The central problem our team identified is a coordination gap: the tools people currently use for group travel were not designed for groups. Flight booking platforms are built for individuals. Hotel booking sites offer at most a "share link". Cost-splitting apps often address only the payment after the fact. No single tool supports the full planning task, so groups fall back on a patchwork of group chats, shared spreadsheets, forwarded links, and informal memory.

Our design goal is a tool that preserves the collaborative, inclusive nature of group trip planning while providing the structure needed to actually reach decisions, commit to them, and keep everyone honest about what has been agreed upon.

2 NEEDFINDING PLAN

2.1 Overview of Activities

Our needfinding plan consists of three activities designed to illuminate different layers of the group travel planning task from different vantage points: a distributed online survey targeting other CS6750 students, a set of semi-structured interviews with frequent group travelers, and a comparative heuristic evaluation of tools commonly used to support group trip planning.

2.1.1 Goal

The goal is to assess the current landscape of tools commonly used to support group travel planning against a structured set of usability and coordination heuristics. Without the need for self-reporting, this activity provides evidence that complements the user evidence from the survey and interviews, and surfaces specific interaction and information design failures in the existing solutions our participants already use. Based on preliminary survey evidence, we anticipate that violations of **H1 (Visibility of System Status)**, **H11 (Visibility of Group Consensus State)**, and **H15 (Financial Transparency)** will be most prevalent, given that users consistently reported difficulty tracking what had been decided and who owed money. All fifteen heuristics were nonetheless applied independently to avoid evaluator confirmation bias. The goal is also to identify strong existing design features and to improve upon those that fall short.

Dividing activities across three separate methods was intentional. A survey allows us to identify patterns across a larger sample without investing too much time after the initial survey creation, but limits depth of response and cannot easily capture some of the nuances of real experiences. Interviews address this gap; individual experiences can be captured in depth and surface motivations that survey data cannot, but are limited in generalizability. The heuristic evaluation allows us to assess the current state of the existing tools without relying on self-report, a useful control since participants may not accurately recall or articulate the source of their frustrations with existing interfaces. Together, the three activities allow us to "triangulate" findings.

2.2 Needfinding Activity 1: Online Survey

2.2.1 Goal

To identify common group travel habits, the most frequent pain points across the population, and which coordination failures are broadly shared versus those that are more specific to certain group sizes or ages.

2.2.2 Participants and Recruitment

We targeted approximately 20 participants, recruited through class participation credit incentives on PeerSurvey and by sharing the survey link with willing participants within our close circle.

2.2.3 Structure

The survey consists of 15 questions covering: frequency of group travel and typical group size; planning roles participants typically play within a group; tools currently used for each stage of trip planning; which stages of planning are perceived as most difficult; what has caused a trip plan to break down or fall through; and what features they would most value in a hypothetical group travel tool. The survey was distributed digitally and estimated to take approximately 10 minutes to complete. The full survey instrument is provided in Appendix A.

2.2.4 Anticipated Biases

Self-Selection Bias may be present in these results due to participants of this survey being mainly recruited via Georgia Tech's peer survey application or ED Discussion board. Respondents may be more inclined to complete this survey if they have stronger opinions on the topic.

Sampling Bias may also be present due to the fact a majority of respondents are technologically adept within a similar age range. There is less likelihood of respondents of older populations or non technologically dependent travelers.

2.3 Needfinding Activity 2: Semi-Structured Interviews

2.3.1 Goal

To gather rich, contextual accounts of real group travel experiences from frequent travelers. This includes, but is not limited to, specific moments of friction, successful coordination strategies, and unmet needs that a survey's closed-ended

questions cannot easily capture.

2.3.2 *Participants and Recruitment*

We targeted five participants who self-identify as frequent group travelers, defined as those who have organized or participated in at least two group trips (three or more people) within the past two years. Participants were recruited through the personal and professional networks of team members, intentionally drawing from outside the CS 6750 class to complement the survey sample with a broader demographic range. This group includes participants with varied roles in past group trips—some who typically lead planning, and some who typically follow.

2.3.3 *Structure*

Each interview ran approximately 20–30 minutes, conducted over video call or in person at the participant’s convenience. The interview followed a semi-structured guide covering the following areas:

- A detailed walkthrough of a specific recent group trip the participant organized or participated in, covering each stage from initial idea to arrival
- What tools or methods they used at each stage of planning, and why
- Where the planning process succeeded and where it broke down
- How financial coordination, such as deposits, reimbursement, splitting costs upfront, was handled, and whether it caused tension within the group
- What an ideal group travel coordination experience would look like

The full interview guide is provided in Appendix B.

2.3.4 *Anticipated Biases*

Recall Bias is likely present, as participants reconstruct past experiences from memory. Memorable failures and conflicts may be over-represented relative to smooth episodes of coordination. This may skew our picture of how frequently things actually fail or break down in practice.

Social Desirability Bias may affect responses when discussing interpersonal friction. Participants may understate the degree of conflict or frustration to attempt to present themselves or their friends favorably to the interviewer.

Small Sample Size limits the generalizability of findings. Five participants can-

not represent the full range of group travel contexts and demographics. Interview findings should be interpreted in conjunction with the broader survey results rather than in isolation. We attempt to combat this bias by having multiple needfinding activities that we can reference and compare with this one.

2.4 Activity 3: Heuristic Evaluation of Existing Tools

2.4.1 Goal

The goal is to assess the current landscape of tools commonly used to support group travel planning against a structured set of usability and coordination heuristics. Without the need for self-reporting, this activity provides evidence that complements the user evidence from the survey and interviews, and surfaces specific interaction and information design failures in the existing solutions our participants already use. The goal is also to build upon the *good* design features that already exist, and improve on the features that currently fall short.

2.4.2 Tools Evaluated

Four tools were selected based on their prevalence in our survey data and their relevance to different stages of the group travel planning task:

- **Google Docs / Sheets.** The most common shared document tool respondents reported using to organize itineraries and track costs.
- **Group Messaging: Messages, Facebook Messenger, Signal.** This is nearly universally used in the coordination layer, as identified in our survey. Used by 100% of respondents
- **Splitwise.** The most frequently named dedicated tool for cost tracking and post-trip redistribution.
- **TripIt.** This is an already existing, purpose-built travel organizer representing the closest existing solution for group travel planning.

2.4.3 Structure

Three team members independently evaluated each tool against the heuristic set below, assigning a severity rating of 0 (no problem) to 4 (usability catastrophe) for each identified violation following Nielsen's severity scale. After independent evaluation, the three evaluators compared notes and resolved any rating discrepancies of two or more points through discussion before finalizing the findings. The full per-tool evaluation notes and severity ratings are provided in Appendix

C.

The evaluation applied the following fifteen heuristics:

Nielsen's Usability Heuristics:

1. Visibility of system status
2. Match between system and the real world
3. User control and freedom
4. Consistency and standards
5. Error prevention
6. Recognition rather than recall
7. Flexibility and efficiency of use
8. Aesthetic and minimalist design
9. Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors
10. Help and documentation
11. Visibility of group consensus state
12. Support for asynchronous participation
13. Graceful handling of plan changes
14. Prevention of conflicting actions
15. Financial transparency

Domain-Specific Group Coordination Heuristics:

16. **Visibility of group consensus state.** Can all members clearly see what has been agreed upon versus what is still under consideration or proposed?
17. **Support for asynchronous participation.** Can members contribute to planning decisions across different schedules and time zones without requiring simultaneous availability?
18. **Graceful handling of plan changes.** Does the tool support updating or replacing a prior decision without creating confusion about the current authoritative state of the plan?
19. **Prevention of conflicting actions.** Does the tool guard against two members simultaneously booking different options for the same trip element, or committing the group to incompatible choices?
20. **Financial transparency.** Does the tool surface the cost implications of decisions proactively and in context during planning, rather than only at the point of payment or settlement?

2.4.4 *Anticipated Biases*

Evaluator Bias is a concern inherent to heuristic evaluation. The method reflects the subjective judgment of the evaluators, who are also the designers of the eventual solution. They may unconsciously identify gaps in existing tools that align with features they are already inclined to build, inflating severity ratings for issues that support their design direction. Independent parallel evaluation partially controls for this, but the shared design context of the team remains a residual source of bias. We intend to control for this overall by ensuring we cross-reference our findings with any other needfinding activity findings so that our results from this activity are corroborated.

Familiarity Effects may also be present. Evaluators who use certain tools regularly may overlook violations they have personally adapted to, while evaluators unfamiliar with a tool may penalize its learning curve rather than genuine usability failures. We attempt to control for this by assigning different team members to evaluate tools they are less personally familiar with.

3 NEEDFINDING RESULTS

3.1 Needfinding Activity 1: Survey

3.2 Execution versus Plan

The needfinding survey was executed as planned. There were 21 total respondents. A majority of respondents were collected from ED Discussion engagement with a handful of respondents within the groups' personal circles. The survey was designed and able to successfully sample respondents' travel and group-trip habits, planning roles, preferred tools, and personal experiences with group travel planning.

3.3 Key Themes

Theme 1: Necessity for a Centralized Platform

The survey revealed that there is no clear structure for groups use to coordinate travel planning. All 21 survey respondents say they used instant messaging as one of their main methods of travel planning within the group. The need for a centralized and more structured approach to this area is supported by 5 unprompted survey free responses explicitly asking for a centralized tool to be

able to coordinate with their travel companions.

Theme 2: Decision Paralysis

Many respondents of the survey activity mentioned making decisions in general are difficult within this process. One respondent discussed disagreements that stemmed from this process and requested something like a "...visual interest map..." to solve this issue. The survey revealed that respondents viewed confirming group agreements as more stressful than coordinating costs. Survey question 11 yielded an average score of 3.38/5 across the 21 responses. The common theme of respondents being unable to come to a decision either due to conflict or overwhelming suggestions poses the need for a streamlined solution that will offload this friction within a centralized interface.

Theme 3: Stress by Role

An interesting finding from our needfinding activities was finding that planning stress is directly correlated with the visibility of decisions being made. Survey respondents who reported being the primary lead in planning felt no difference in stress between solo traveling and group traveling. While respondents involved in groups with more distributed roles in planning regularly reported feeling more stressed as shown in figure 1.

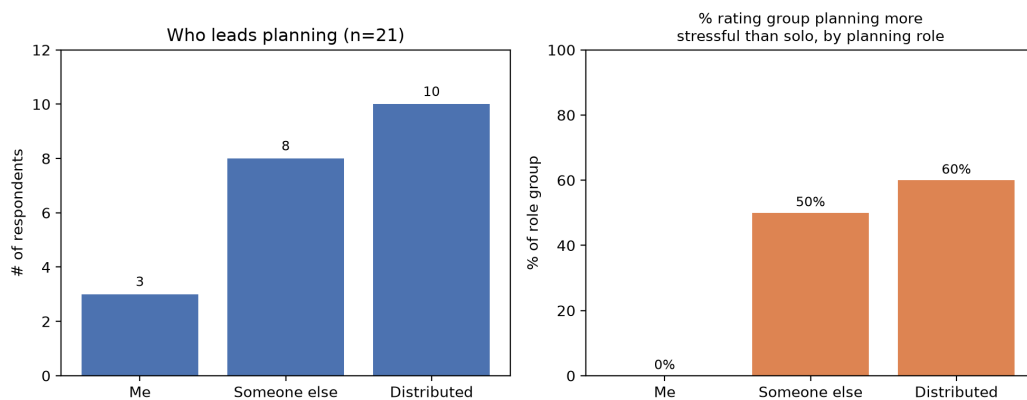


Figure 1—Group planning stress by role, derived from survey responses for Q5 and Q13.

This identifies a need of **decision visibility** throughout the whole process of planning for all members of the group.

3.4 Needfinding Activity 2: Semi-Structured Interviews

3.4.1 *Execution versus Plan*

Five semi-structured interviews were conducted over video call and in person, each lasting approximately 20–30 minutes. All five participants were sourced through the personal networks of team members and were outside the CS 6750 class. All participants had organized or participated in at least two group trips within the past two years. One participant was in her mid-forties, providing a demographic standout to the otherwise younger survey sample; the remaining four ranged from 27 to 33 years old. Roles in prior group trips varied: two described themselves as primary organizers, two described distributed planning roles, and one described themselves primarily as a participant who contributed preferences but followed plans made by others. Complete interview notes are provided in Appendix B.

3.4.2 *High-Level Findings*

The five interviews surfaced consistent friction across contexts that varied in purpose (personal travel, family travel, and professional travel), group size (ranging from five to eleven participants), and planning structure (organizer-led vs. distributed). Despite this variety, the same underlying failure patterns recurred in every account: **information without a clear status, decisions that stall because no one wants to commit the group, and one person bearing financial risk for others before any commitment is secured.**

Theme A: Shared Information that Lacks State Incurs Real Costs. Every participant described a specific incident in which the ambiguous status of shared information—a hotel link, a proposed date, a tentative reservation—led to a tangible mistake or significant confusion. Two participants described scenarios where different group members simultaneously held incompatible beliefs about whether a specific item (a show booking, a beach house reservation) was confirmed or still under consideration. One participant (P3) described her father calling to ask whether the beach house was booked, two months after she had already paid the deposit. Another (P4) described a group member who booked the wrong nighttime show because he had saved an old screenshot of an earlier option and did not know it had been replaced. A third (P2) described two days of uncertainty in a five-person group about whether anyone had reserved the

hotel after a booking link expired.

This theme extends and deepens the survey finding about platform fragmentation. The interview evidence suggests the problem is not merely that information is scattered across tools—it is that the same piece of information can mean "we are considering this" to one person and "we agreed on this" to another simultaneously, with no mechanism in any current tool to explicitly resolve that ambiguity.

Theme B: Pre-Trip Financial Commitment is the Single Highest-Stakes Moment in the Planning Process. Every participant cited a specific financial event—almost always a large upfront payment by one person on behalf of the group—as a turning point in the planning experience. Before that payment, the trip feels flexible and low-stakes. After it, the person who paid becomes a creditor and the rest of the group becomes a set of debtors, and the social dynamic of the friendship or family changes accordingly.

One participant (P1) described chasing seven friends for Airbnb reimbursement for months after a bachelorette trip, eventually setting a deadline with a social ultimatum: Another participant (P4) described a friend who put \$3,000 on a credit card to cover upfront deposits, intending to collect reimbursement afterward, and was still owed money by two members eight months after the trip. A third (P3) described having to quietly negotiate separate, lower payment contributions with two family members whose budgets could not match the agreed-upon amount, specifically to avoid surfacing the budget gap in the group chat.

The interviews distinguished this finding from the survey's cost-splitting friction (Q12, mean 2.6/5). Participants were generally not frustrated with the *math* of splitting costs, as tools like Splitwise handle that adequately. The source of friction is the *timing* of financial commitment: one person takes on full financial exposure before others have formally committed, yet collecting reimbursement from friends afterward introduces a social asymmetry that can persist well beyond the trip itself.

3.5 Activity 3: Heuristic Evaluation Results

3.5.1 Execution versus Plan

The heuristic evaluation of the four tools surfaced consistent gaps in group coordination support across every tool examined. Our execution of this was very

consistent with our needfinding plan. We evaluated the 4 different platforms that were most commonly used for trip planning and payment splitting.

Google Docs/Sheets scored well on editability of information, but offered no visibility into who had viewed or agreed to the current document state. There is no affordance for signaling approval, flagging disagreement, or marking an item as finalized versus still under consideration.

Group messaging scored well on real-time communication but performed poorly on nearly every coordination heuristic: information is buried in a linear stream, which make links inaccessible over time as the conversation goes on, and there is no mechanism for reaching and recording group consensus. There is no structural separation between discussions that are ongoing and decisions that have been made.

Splitwise addressed financial settlement effectively but operated entirely after the fact. It is a reimbursement tool, not a planning tool, and offers no support for the financial coordination that occurs during the decision-making stage—specifically, the ability to see whether a proposed option falls within each member’s budget before committing to it. Additionally, someone in the group is still fronting the cost.

TripIt offered itinerary organization for individual travelers but provided minimal group-facing features: no collaborative decision-making, no voting or consensus mechanism, and no shared financial view.

3.6 Key Insights

Across all three needfinding activities, three core insights emerged that will drive the design phase.

Insight 1: Groups need a single source of truth that evolves safely. Information fragmentation is the root cause of most group travel failures identified across all three activities. Eighty-seven percent of survey respondents used multiple platforms for a single trip, and no respondent used a dedicated group travel tool. Links shared in chats expire; spreadsheets fall out of sync; no one knows what the "official" or "final" version of the plan is. Interview participants described discovering, sometimes only after arrival, that a booking one member believed was finalized was still in draft. This is a pattern confirmed by the heuristic evaluation’s finding that no existing tool provides any mechanism for explicitly

marking items as confirmed versus under consideration. **A successful design must maintain a structured, reliable record of what is under consideration versus what has been agreed.**

Insight 2: Financial friction shows up in design needs even when it is not the primary pain point. Survey data revealed a nuanced split: respondents rated trouble confirming group agreements at 3.1 out of 5, but trouble splitting costs at only 2.2—suggesting that coordination friction outweighs financial friction in day-to-day experience. However, when asked what they wished current tools did, cost visualization and shared cost tracking appeared independently in multiple open-ended responses. The interviews clarified this: the friction is not in the math (existing apps like Splitwise can handle this) but in the *timing*. one person bears full financial risk before others have committed, and the act of collecting reimbursement from friends afterward changes the social dynamic of the group. There is an unmet need for financial awareness *during* the planning process, before commitments are made.

Insight 3: Decision-making requires explicit structure to converge. Forty percent of survey respondents cited group consensus and decision-making as the single most frustrating aspect of group travel planning—more than any other factor. Interview participants described trips that fell apart completely because no one felt authorized to finalize a choice, and the interviews added an important insight into this: the stall is not caused by too many options or too little information. It is caused by a social dynamic in which authority to commit is ambiguous. The penalty for a poor choice falls on one person, so no one wants to take the first step in finalizing something. Existing tools, such as group chats, shared documents, and travel apps alike, provide no mechanism for moving from "discussing" to "decided." A successful design must provide a way to reach closure on group decisions that feels legitimate and inclusive, without requiring one member to take unilateral control.

4 INITIAL BRAINSTORMING PLAN

After sharing the main findings from our needfinding activities, our team will use a two-stage brainstorming process. We will divide this larger problem into smaller areas, including availability, destination selection, transportation, lodging, activities, budgeting, group decision making, booking, and handling later changes.

The first stage will be asynchronous individual brainstorming in our shared document. This format works with our different schedules and gives each team member time to generate ideas before being influenced by the rest of the group. Each member will aim to contribute approximately 5-7 short ideas. Ideas will not need to be fully developed or immediately feasible, since the goal of this stage is to explore a wide range of possibilities instead of becoming attached to the first reasonable solution.

After individual brainstorming, we will hold a 40-minute group session with all five team members. We will review every submitted idea using a round-robin format, with approximately 1 minute for a person to explain each idea. During this part of the session, the team will not criticize, rank, or vote on ideas. Members will be encouraged to add new ideas and build on existing ones.

The purpose of this approach is intended to reduce several common brainstorming problems. Individual work with a set number of ideas prevent social loafing, while brainstorming separately before meeting reduces conformity and fixation. Timed turns also reduce production blocking and prevent one person from dominating the discussion. The brainstorming meeting will end with several alternatives rather than one final decision. We will then hold a separate selection discussion and choose at least three alternatives based on our needfinding results, scope, feasibility, and ability to evaluate them with participants.

5 BRAINSTORMING RESULTS

5.1 Summary of Ideas Generated

Following the two-stage brainstorming plan described in Section 4, each team member submitted 5-7 ideas independently before the group's synchronous session. The combined set addressed the major sub-problems identified in our needfinding phase: destination selection, schedule coordination, shared draft-

to-final itinerary management, group decision-making, cost visibility, and payment handling. Ideas ranged from interaction-level concepts (a swipe-based voting model borrowed from dating apps) to structural concepts (a two-board draft/finalized workspace) to role-based delegation concepts (assigning planning categories to individual members).

In the round-robin session, every idea was presented without evaluation or elimination. The team then held a separate selection discussion and identified three alternatives for prototyping based on how each would address a different core insight from needfinding, and how each could be independently evaluated by participants.

5.2 Selected Design Alternatives

Alternative 1: TripSwipe was selected because it most directly addresses Survey Theme 2 (decision paralysis) by converting group voting into a low-effort swipe interaction and offloading itinerary generation. This removes the need for any one member to unilaterally **propose** or **commit** the group to a plan. There were similar voting concepts, but we chose this for our first prototype because the swipe interaction scales across all trip components and is a familiar interaction pattern, especially for the 18-45 year old demographic.

Alternative 2: TripOD was selected because it most directly addresses Survey Theme 1 (the need for a centralized platform). The two-board model (Draft for options under consideration and Finalized for agreed items) provides an explicit distinction between tentative and confirmed information that existing tools fail to offer. Additionally, embedding financial visibility and payment tracking in the same workspace also addresses Theme 3 (stress by role) by making costs visible to all members, not just the organizer.

Alternative 3: TripRoles was selected because it addresses Theme 3 most directly by redistributing planning responsibility across the group, taking the burden off any single person. Assigning each category (lodging, flights, activities) to a different member reduces the concentration of planning work on a single organizer, which was the primary driver of unevenly distributed stress, as identified in the survey.

6 INITIAL PROTOTYPING

6.1 Prototype 1: Swipe Based Itineraries (TripSwipe)

The first prototype tries to create the travel planning experience into somewhat of a game. Instead of mapping out itineraries, users of a group fill in their preferences for a trip (B), an AI agent will then create a handful of variations of feasible itineraries based on those user preferences. Users will then swipe on those options dating app style to cast votes on the preferred option (D). The cards they swipe on can be expanded to show a more detailed view. The trip itinerary with the most votes is shown in the more detailed format allowing users to lock it in or request for a re-vote (E) as shown in figure 2.

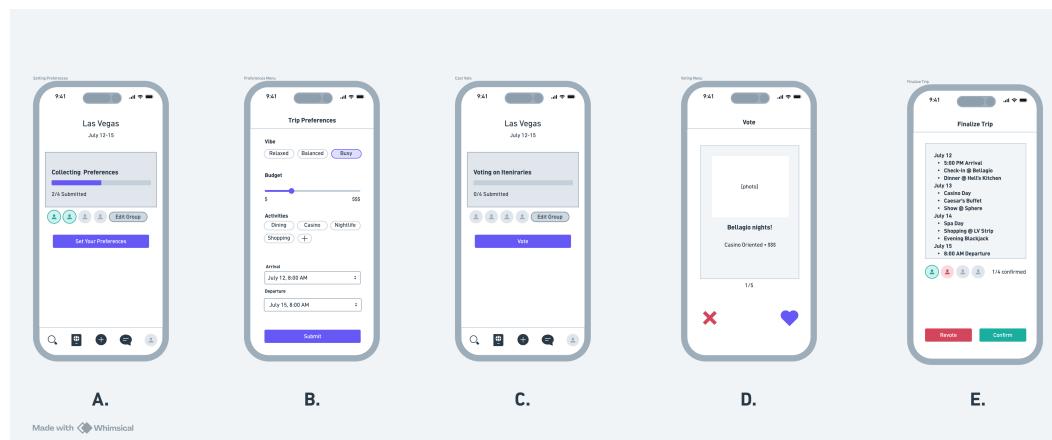


Figure 2—Medium fidelity Wire frame: TripSwipe

6.1.1 Design Rationale

This prototype builds off of Don Norman's principle of simplicity by minimizing the amount of components within the applications UI (Norman, 2013). It also tries to build off of the familiarity of the interaction convention of dating apps in the hopes of improving the usability of the app. By offloading the itinerary planning to an AI model and showing off this removes some of the stress of planing and having a designated planning "lead" within the group, allowing this cognitive process to be truly distributed as described by Hutchins (Hutchins, 1995). The inclusion of detailed views in final few stages of this workflow aims to remove the stress induced ambiguity that is common within these distributed situations as described in section 3.

6.2 Prototype 2: Shared Group Board (TripOD)

The second prototype aims to leverage a purely user centric experience within a centralized plannign application. Each stage of planning the trip involves drafting and voting even from deciding on where to go as shown in figure 3.

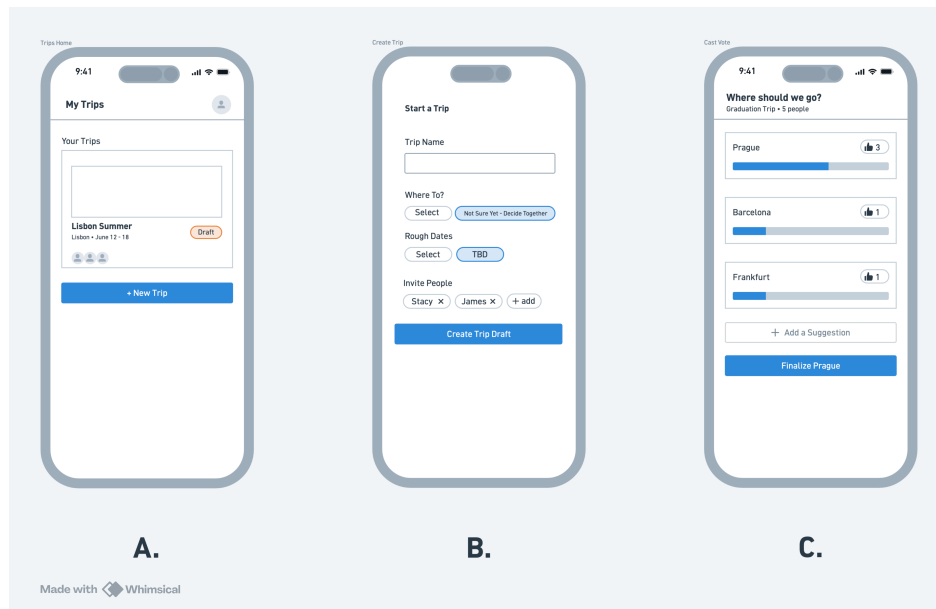


Figure 3—Medium fidelity Wire frame: TripOD Trip Creation Workflow

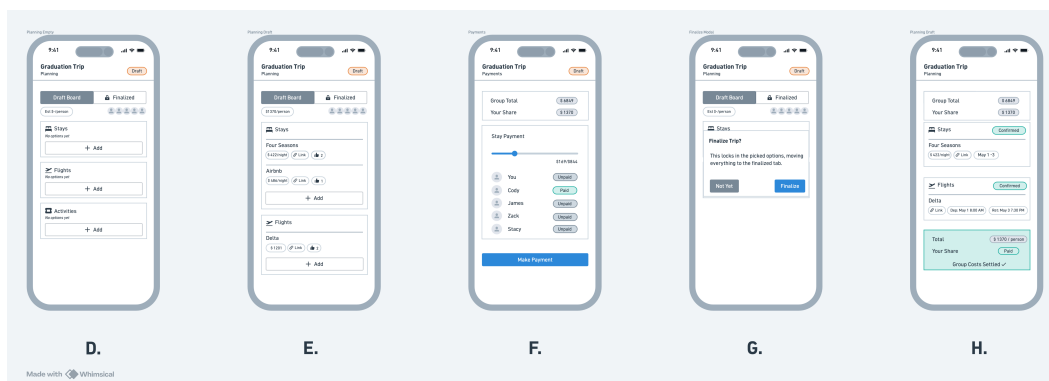


Figure 4—Medium fidelity Wire frame: TripOD Trip Planning Workflow

This prototype considers everything from stays, flights, and activities allowing users to put in their preferences and vote on them in the draft board shown in

frames D. and E. of figure 4. Once a trip is decided there is sections that automatically distributes costs among users within the group, streamlining the process of covering upfront costs of travel without disagreements. When everything is finalized, all the options put within the draft board is locked in allowing users to only see a finalized dashboard and summaries on outstanding balances within the group.

6.2.1 *Design Rationale*

Based off of the same concept of familiarity that the first prototype uses, the angle of familiarity is more directly in line with the responses from our needfinding survey. A notable number of respondents reported using instant messaging and shared spreadsheets as modes of planning during group travel. Using Norman's principles, this design alternative aims to mimic affordances from those applications to translate the user's already existing mental model of the task onto this application (Norman, 2013). Following the principles of prototyping by Houde and Hill, this mockup is scoped to investigate role and look and feel of the solution to see if the detailed dashboard design resolves the decision paralysis problem identified in needfinding (Houde and Hill, 1997).

6.3 Prototype 3: Role Base Planning (TripRoles)

The third prototype aims to reduce the stress associated with distributed planning by assigning responsibilities to members within the group. Instead of every member researching every aspect of the trip such as stays, flights, and activities, the group assigns each planning category to a designated member. Each member then researches and proposed their preferred options for their assigned category. The rest of the group can then review, provide feedback and vote on the options. If the proposed options is rejected, the assigned member can revise the proposal base on the feedback and submitted it again. This process continues until all the planning categories have been finalized.

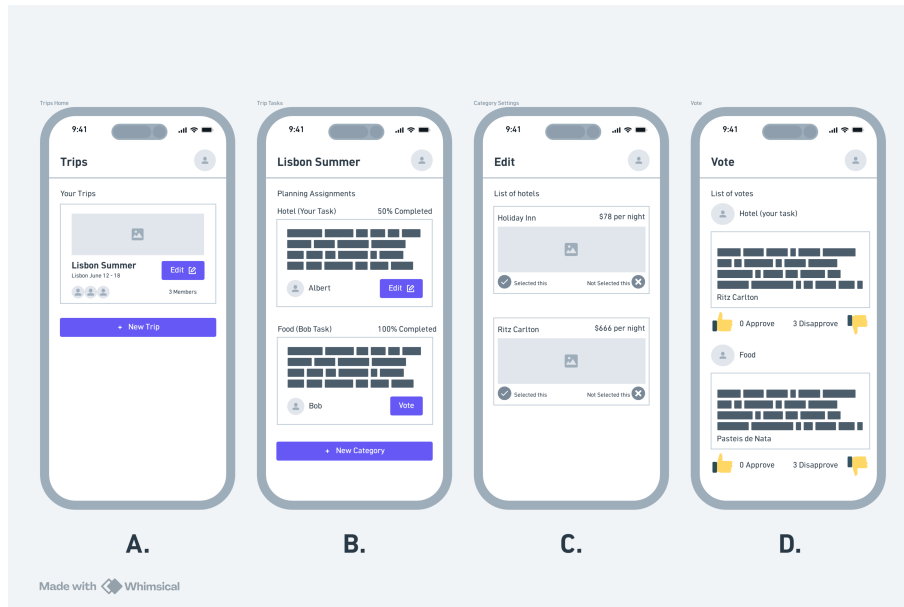


Figure 5—Medium fidelity Wire frame: TripRoles

6.3.1 Design Rationale

Based on the same concept of familiarity that the second prototypes uses, this design focuses on the planning responsibilities identified in our needfinding survey. A notable number respondents from our needfinding survey responded that unclear planning roles lead to higher levels of stress when planning a group trip. Rather than requiring every member to come up with a complete plan for every category, this design assigns each planning category to an individual member. This allows each member to focus only on the category they are responsible for, making the planning process less stressful.

Using the Norman principle of visibility, constraints, and conceptual models, this design alternative aims to reduce ambiguity by clearly showing each member responsibilities (Norman, 2013). This design is also based on Hutchin concept of distributed cognition. By assigning each planning category to a different member, the workload is distributed across the group, allowing each member to focus on their assigned task and reducing the stress associated with planning (Hutchins, 1995).

7 EVALUATION PLANNING

7.1 Evaluation Goal

For the initial evaluation, we narrow the larger group-travel domain to the task of **helping a group turn individual preferences and tentative options into one agreed-upon, up-to-date trip plan**. The goal is to compare three medium-fidelity alternatives: (A) TripSwipe, which emphasizes preference collection and swipe-based itinerary voting; (B) TripOD, which emphasizes a centralized draft-to-final planning board; and (C) TripRoles, which emphasizes explicit division of planning responsibility and group approval of category-specific options.

The evaluation will examine how well each alternative helps users understand the current state of a trip, contribute their own input, identify what remains unresolved, and feel that the group decision process is fair. We will use the results both to select a promising overall direction and to identify features from the other alternatives that should be combined during the second design iteration.

7.2 Participants and Recruitment

We will recruit participants through the CS 6750 PeerSurvey system. Prior group-travel planning experience is not required because all participants will receive the same shared scenario; however, the survey records whether participants have prior experience, what role they normally play, and how recently they participated in group-trip planning. These background measures will be used to describe the sample and contextualize the findings. The study is expected to take approximately 10–12 minutes.

7.3 Study Design and Procedure

The evaluation will use a within-subject design in which every participant reviews all three prototypes in a single PeerSurvey questionnaire. The survey uses one fixed presentation order: TripSwipe first, TripOD second, and TripRoles third. Participants will first answer five background questions. They will then receive a shared scenario in which five friends must collect preferences, compare possible plans, agree on one option, and understand what is finalized and what still requires attention. They will be instructed to evaluate the interaction concept and information organization.

For each prototype, participants will answer two objective multiple-choice com-

prehension questions, six five-point rating questions, and one open-ended feedback question. After reviewing all three alternatives, participants will rank them, select the prototype that should serve as the foundation for the final design, explain their choice, select features to preserve, and identify any remaining group-travel problems.

7.4 Quantitative Measures

The comprehension response for each prototype will be scored from zero to two using a rubric established before data collection. One point will be awarded when the participant correctly identifies a valid way to contribute personal input, and one point will be awarded when the participant correctly identifies the cue or condition indicating that the group can finalize the trip.

Participants will also rate each prototype on the following measures:

- Ease of understanding the current planning state
- Ease of contributing personal preferences or proposed options
- Ease of understanding the next action
- Confidence that group preferences and constraints are represented
- Perceived fairness of the group decision process
- Overall usefulness for planning an actual group trip

Each item will use a fully labeled five-point response scale appropriate to the construct. Participants will also provide a first-, second-, and third-choice ranking; select which prototype should serve as the foundation for the final design; and select any features they believe should be retained. Because PeerSurvey does not enforce unique selections across the three ranking questions, responses that repeat a prototype in the ranking will be excluded from rank-specific analysis but retained for all other measures.

7.5 Qualitative Measures

After each prototype, participants will describe what they liked most and one thing they would change, remove, or add. At the end of the survey, participants will explain why they selected a particular prototype as the best foundation, identify important problems not addressed by any prototype, and provide additional suggestions. These responses will help us examine concerns that may not be captured by ratings, including the distinction between draft and finalized information, reactions to financial pledges, perceived pressure to agree with the

group, and preferences for automation versus direct user control.

7.6 Analysis Plan

For each prototype, we will calculate the median, interquartile range, and response distribution for the comprehension score and each rating measure. Because all participants evaluate all three alternatives and the measures are ordinal, we will use Friedman tests to compare the prototypes. Final rankings and foundation selections will be summarized with counts, percentages, and median rank.

Open-ended responses will be analyzed through thematic coding. Expected categories include clarity, control, trust, fairness, decision support, information organization, financial transparency, and planning progress. We will discuss disagreements, summarize repeated strengths, weaknesses, and requested features for each prototype.

7.7 Potential Biases and Limitations

The fixed prototype order creates a possible order effect: participants may understand later prototypes more quickly after learning the task from Prototype A, or they may give lower ratings to later prototypes because of fatigue. Conversely, the most recently viewed prototype may benefit from a recency effect in the final comparison. Because the order is the same for every participant, order and prototype cannot be fully separated; we will therefore avoid treating small rating differences as conclusive evidence of design superiority.

8 EVALUATION RESULTS

8.1 Participants and Execution

The initial evaluation received 21 complete and consenting responses through the PeerSurvey system. Every participant had previously participated in planning a leisure trip involving at least three people. Eight participants (38.1%) had served as one of the main organizers on a prior trip, eight (38.1%) had shared planning responsibilities, and five (23.8%) reported that someone else handled most of the planning. Eighteen participants (85.7%) had planned a group trip within the previous year, and 19 (90.5%) had done so within the previous two years. Ten participants completed the survey on a smartphone, seven on a laptop, two on a tablet, and two on a desktop computer.

The study followed the planned within-subject procedure. Each participant reviewed the three prototypes in the fixed order TripSwipe, TripOD, and TripRoles, then answered two comprehension questions, six five-point rating questions, and one open-ended question for each design. Participants concluded by ranking the prototypes, selecting a design foundation, choosing features to retain, and describing needs not fully addressed by any alternative. All 21 responses were retained for comprehension, rating, foundation-selection, feature-selection, and qualitative analyses. Three participants repeated the same prototype across all three ranking fields despite instructions not to do so. Their other answers were retained, but those three ranking sets were excluded, leaving 18 valid rankings.

8.2 Quantitative Results

8.2.1 *Prototype Comprehension*

Comprehension was high across the three designs. TripSwipe received 36 correct answers out of 42 possible item responses (85.7%), TripOD received 36 of 42 (85.7%), and TripRoles received 38 of 42 (90.5%). Fifteen participants earned the maximum TripSwipe score of two, 16 earned the maximum TripOD score, and 19 earned the maximum TripRoles score. A Friedman test found no statistically significant difference among the comprehension scores, $\chi^2(2) = 1.00$, $p = .607$. Thus, participants generally understood the intended purpose and key interface state of all three concepts.

8.2.2 *Prototype Ratings*

Table 1 reports medians and interquartile ranges for the repeated measures. Friedman tests were used because the same participants evaluated all three prototypes and the response scales were ordinal.

The ratings do not support a claim that one full prototype was reliably better than the others. The descriptive patterns were still useful for design. TripOD had the highest median confidence that the design represented member preferences, financial commitments, and constraints. TripSwipe showed the strongest descriptive pattern for ease of contributing input, while TripSwipe and TripRoles received somewhat stronger fairness ratings than TripOD. Because these differences were not statistically significant, we treat them as signals for iteration rather than established performance differences.

Table 1—Initial prototype results reported as median [first quartile, third quartile].

Measure	TripSwipe	TripOD	TripRoles	$\chi^2(2)$	p
Comprehension score (0–2)	2 [1, 2]	2 [2, 2]	2 [2, 2]	1.00	.607
Understand current state	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	1.02	.600
Contribute personal input	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	4.78	.092
Understand the next action	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	1.22	.544
Confidence needs are represented	3 [2, 4]	4 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	3.93	.140
Perceived fairness	4 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	4 [3, 4]	1.04	.594
Overall usefulness	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	3 [3, 4]	5.27	.072

8.2.3 Overall Preference and Requested Features

Among the 18 valid rankings, TripOD was ranked first by nine participants, TripSwipe by five, and TripRoles by four. The separate foundation question, which was valid for all 21 responses, produced a similar descriptive result: nine participants (42.9%) chose TripOD, seven (33.3%) chose TripSwipe, and five (23.8%) chose TripRoles. TripOD therefore received most selections, but not a statistically decisive preference.

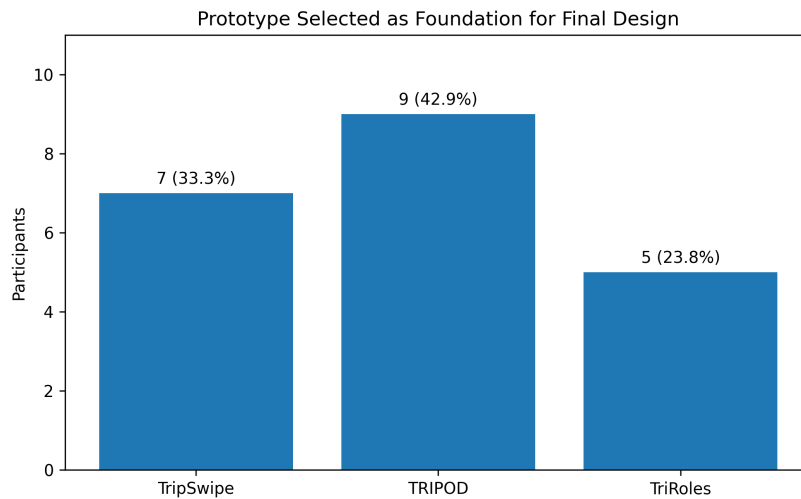


Figure 6—Prototype selected as the foundation for the final design ($n = 21$).

The feature selections strongly favored a hybrid design. Private preference entry and estimated total/per-person cost were each selected by 13 participants (61.9%). A personal budget range and trip vibe or pace preferences were each selected by

12 participants (57.1%). Final confirmation or re-voting and group voting were each selected by 11 participants (52.4%). A centralized shared workspace and visible Paid/Pledged/Pending statuses were each selected by ten participants (47.6%), while separate Draft and Finalized views were selected by nine (42.9%). Figure 7 shows the ten most frequently selected features.

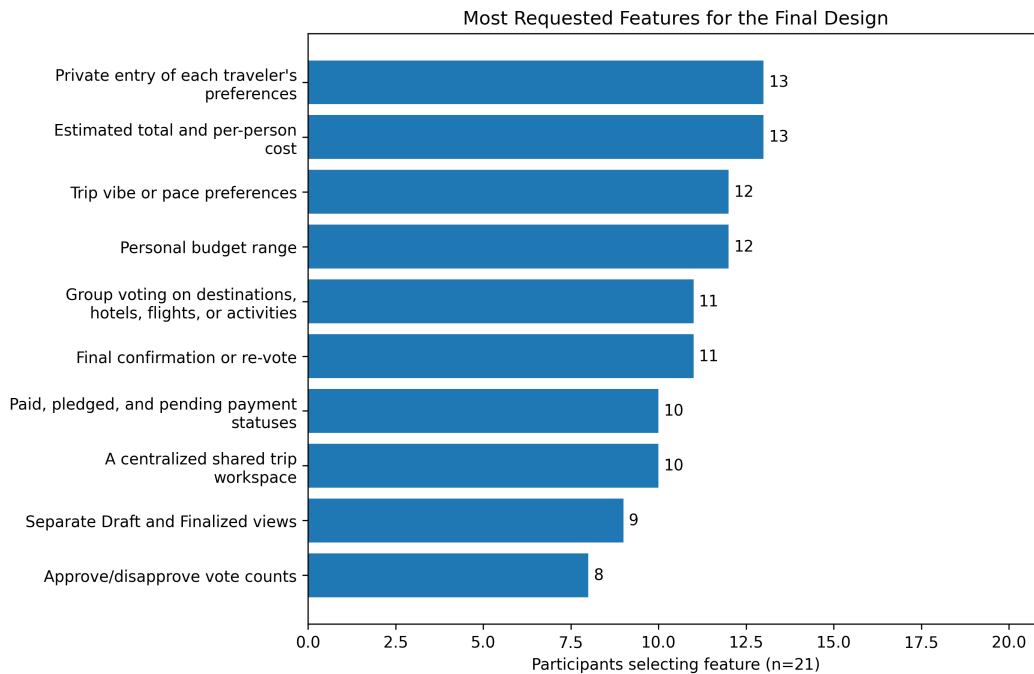


Figure 7—Most frequently requested features for the final design (n = 21).

8.3 Qualitative Results

The open-ended responses were reviewed in two passes. The first pass identified repeated strengths, concerns, and requested additions. The second consolidated related comments into broader themes. Blank answers and entries such as “N/A,” “no,” or a period were treated as non-substantive; one response could contribute to more than one theme. The coding was interpretive and was not accompanied by an inter-rater reliability statistic, which is considered in the limitations below.

8.3.1 *TripSwipe: Low Effort, but Insufficient Nuance*

Participants frequently described TripSwipe as quick, familiar, and low effort. The private preference screen and swipe interaction let members contribute

without first researching or constructing a complete itinerary. One participant compared the preference screen to ordering from a short menu, while another said that the low-effort format fit into a busy schedule.

The main weakness was that binary swiping flattened conditional preferences. Users wanted ranked choices and distinctions between a preference, a compromise, and an option that could not work. They also requested location filters, visible prices before voting, budget ceilings, accessibility needs, accommodation voting, and the ability for each traveler to protect one high-priority activity. Several participants wanted a clearer final state, such as a sentence stating how many confirmations remained, a notification when their input was required, and an explanation of how the combined votes produced the selected itinerary. TripSwipe successfully reduced effort, but its simplicity also removed information necessary for confident commitment.

8.3.2 TripOD: Strong Source of Truth, but Information Heavy

TripOD was praised for bringing destinations, lodging, flights, activities, costs, and member commitments into one workspace. Participants particularly valued the separation between Draft and Finalized plans, the per-person cost summary, and the visibility of paid and unpaid balances.

The major criticism was information overload. Participants called the design cluttered, verbose, or difficult to process at once. They asked for a simpler entry point, a short “Needs Your Attention” summary, and a walkthrough for less experienced organizers. They also identified missing change-management behavior: editing a reservation, responding to price changes, replacing an option, handling cancellations and refunds, and controlling who may view or edit details.

8.3.3 TripRoles: Clear Responsibility, but Fragile Delegation

Participants liked TripRoles’ division of work, visible progress, and ability to prevent one organizer from researching every category. Some also felt that assigning ownership could lead to better researched options before the full group voted.

However, participants worried that the workflow depended too heavily on every category owner finishing the assignment. They requested reminders, fallback rules, and the ability to share, swap, or reassign a category. Several comments noted that the design would fit poorly when one or two people prefer to lead the trip. Participants requested reasons for rejection, alternative proposals, and

a summarized final itinerary. TripRoles offered useful accountability ideas, but rigid task assignment should remain optional.

8.3.4 Needs Not Fully Addressed by Any Prototype

The final questions exposed needs that crossed all three designs. Participants asked for hard date and budget constraints, ranked or conditional preferences, accessibility requirements, protected downtime, flexible rather than rigid itineraries, price-change and refund handling, and a low-effort mode that only shows decisions requiring a particular member's input. Some also wanted fairer cost handling and a way for each traveler to preserve one must-do activity. These responses suggest that voting is not sufficient by itself: a final design should distinguish negotiable preferences from constraints that must not be violated.

8.4 Interpretation and Limitations

The combined evidence supports using TripOD's centralized Draft-to-Final structure as the architectural foundation, while adding TripSwipe's low-effort private preference entry and retaining only optional, flexible accountability features from TripRoles.

9 SECOND ITERATION PLANNING

The goal of this project is to design a tool that preserves the collaborative and inclusive nature of group trip planning while providing the structure needed to reach decisions, commit to them, and keep everyone updated on what has been agreed on. During the first design iteration, our team has conducted needfinding activities, brainstormed three design alternatives, developed medium fidelity prototypes, and evaluated them with participants. The first iteration provided valuable insights into user preference and areas for further improvement. The evaluation showed that participants understood the design purpose and workflow of all three prototypes. They also identified the strengths and weakness of each design and they would like a prototype that combined the best features from all three design.

Based on the finding, the goal of the second iteration is to develop a high fidelity prototype that combine TripSwipe quick and low effort preference collaboration, TripPod centralized workspace place for managing destinations, lodging, flights, activities, costs, and member commitments, and TripRoles division of planning

responsibilities with visible progress from researching every category. The prototype will also address the weakness identified during the first evaluation. The binary swiping interaction will have additional preference, the planning interface will be simplified to improve usability, and the workflow will support reminders and the ability to share, swap, or reassign a category. The final evaluation will then examine whether combined design improves the overall user experience for group travel planning.

10 FINAL PROTOTYPE

10.1 Prototype Access

The final prototype is a clickable prototype designed through Figma. The final prototype can be accessed with the following [PROTOTYPE LINK](#). After following the link, you will be in the prototype view of the design where you will be at the beginning of the flow for creating a new trip. The prototype can be navigated using the arrow keys as inputs or clicking through the design as intended. The flow takes the user to go from the home page to creating and voting on individual preferences. Adding and voting on activities, flights, and stays on the draft board. Then lastly finalizing trip expenses and trip details voted on by the group.

10.2 Summary

The final prototype is a more functional version of the Whimsical prototypes presented in section 6. The final prototype is developed in Figma and leverages a combination of the functionalities featured within the first three design alternatives. With TripOD being a slight favorite from respondents for the future foundation of a design prototype as shown in figure 6, the final prototype takes a lot of the operational flow of the TripOD design alternative. From the Trip-Swipe design alternative, the final prototype takes in individual preference entry and a swiping voting mechanic to streamline the voting processes for core trip details. As shown in section 8.2.1, TripRoles earned the highest comprehension score, therefore the explicit thumbs-up and thumbs-down mechanic from this prototype is used within the final prototype. Additionally, a payment state status of paid, pledged, and pending is implemented when managing trip costs as requested by one of the free responses in appendix G. One respondent of the survey said in one of the free response sections said that visibility of payment status, "...keeps awkward conversations about who has paid and who hasn't down since

it's viewable to everyone going...".

10.3 My Trips - Application Homepage

The my trips section acts as the homepage for the mobile application. This is where new trips can be added, trips in progress, and finalized trips can be accessed. Trips that are incomplete and not finalized are marked as drafts, and trips that are finalized are marked with a green indicator indicating finalized as shown in figure 8.

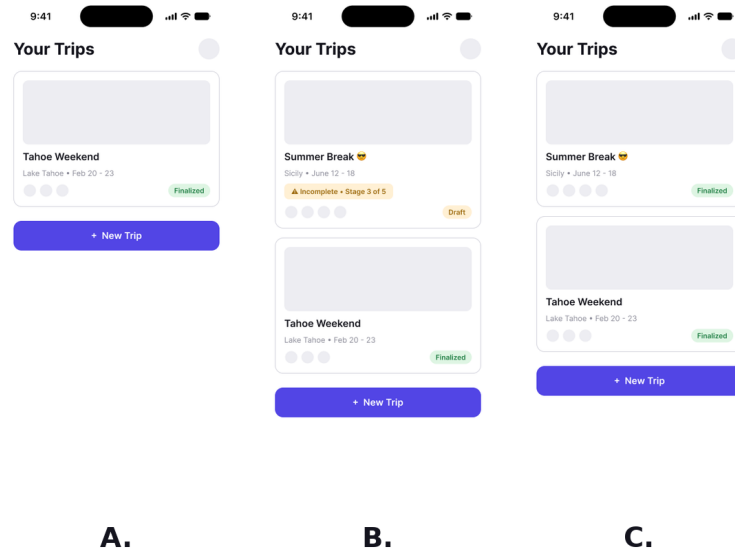


Figure 8—My Trips Application Homepage

Trip drafts will allow the user to pick up at the stage where they left off, while finalized trip cards will lead the user to a detailed summary of the trip details finalized by the group. The colored pills indicating if a trip is in the draft or finalized staged works off of Don Norman's principle of simplicity and feedback. These pills aim to decrease the gulf of evaluation on current trip state and status.

10.4 New Trip Setup

A new trip can be initialized by a user where a user can start a trip and set up the basics like a trip name and invites everyone all the users participating with the group trip as shown in 9. This is done without the input of anyone else within the group, this is the only workflow within the application where a single

user takes ownership of the trip. Other major trip decisions are deferred to other workflows where all members within the group can provide input to support the survey respondent preference to having a distributed effort in planning the trip, rather than having one person have majority ownership.

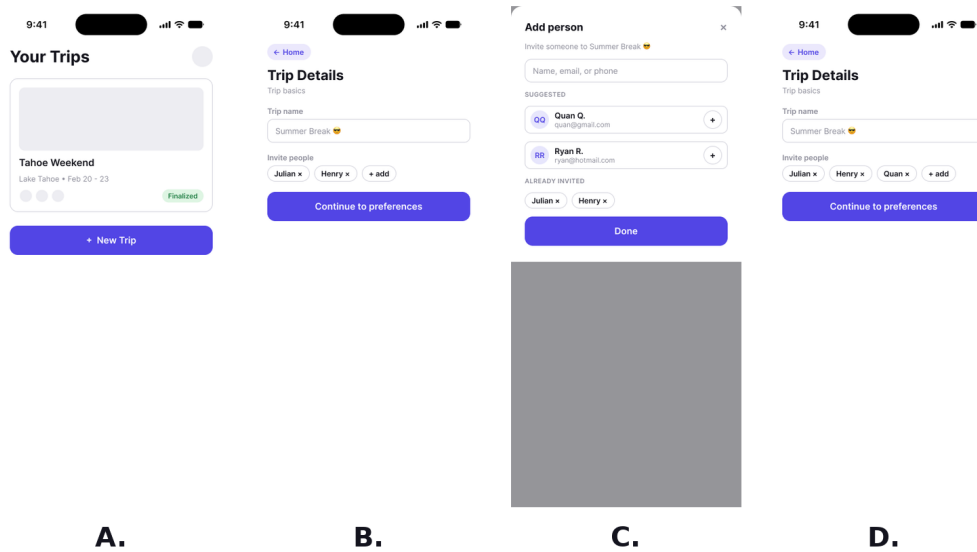


Figure 9—New trip initialization

10.5 Preference Selection

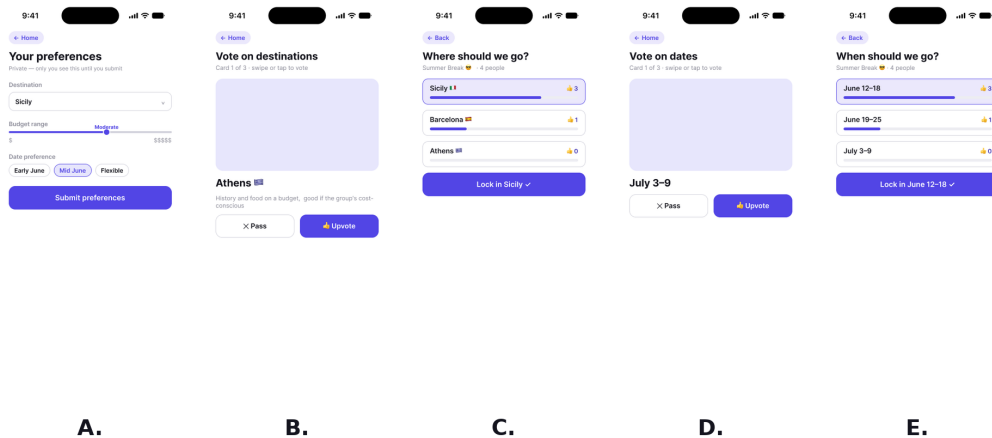


Figure 10—Preference input and voting

The preference input and selection workflow is shown in figure 10. Each person in the group first enters their preferences for date, budget range, and destination individually before the group can vote on preference entries using a swipe or tap mechanism common in modern dating apps. This mechanic is taken directly from the TripSwipe design alternative. Results are the automatically calculated, having moving the trip forward with the group majority vote. This mechanic is leveraged to help streamline the decision making process for the group to decide on core concepts of trip dates and destination before moving forward with any other planning activities. The budget range preferences of each member are averaged and then used in the planning dashboard interface.

10.6 Draft Board

The draft board is the shared interface that unifies the shared spreadsheets, group messaging, and other tools respondents reported to using for group travel planning during our needfinding activities. The interface allows the group to add options and vote on three different categories being stays, flights, and activities as shown in figure 11. Cost indicators are accompanied by every option that is placed in each category and coordinates with the aggregated group preferred budget indicator shown with the purple pill at the header of the interface.

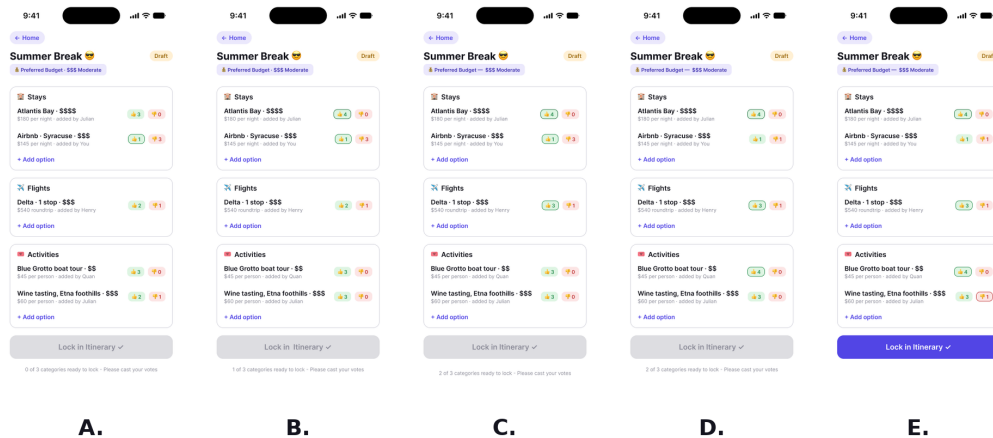


Figure 11—Shared planning board for stays, flights, and activities.

To finalize the group trip itinerary, each category must be finalized using the thumbs up or thumbs down buttons that was derived from the TripRoles prototype. For a category to be settled there must be a clear majority preference

for one of the options, and for activities, all options added that have majority positive input will be advanced past this itinerary planning phase. Since voting is not restricted to a single option within each category, this forces the group to come to a decision to finalize, attempting to solve the issue of decision paralysis as discussed in section 3.3.

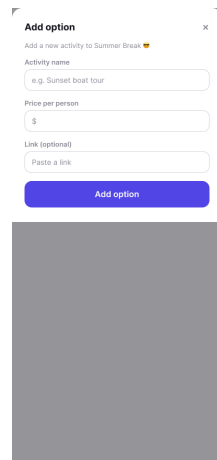
The image shows a mobile app modal titled "Add option" with a close button (X) in the top right corner. Below the title is a subtitle "Add a new activity to Summer Break 🌞". The form contains four input fields: "Activity name" with a placeholder "e.g. Sunset boat tour", "Price per person" with a placeholder "\$", "Link (optional)" with a placeholder "Paste a link", and a blue "Add option" button at the bottom. Below the modal is a large gray rectangular area representing the background of the app.

Figure 12—Option adding modal

If a user plans to add an option, they may fill out the details of the stay, flight, or activity manually through a modal before it shows up on the draft board as shown in figure 12

10.7 Expense Agreements

After finalizing an itinerary, the user is taken to the expense agreements interface where they are met with a overall trip cost summary. Users are allowed to update the finalized itinerary after seeing the proposed expenses by using the call for re-vote button at the bottom of the interface. If a majority of the group calls for re-vote, they will be brought back to the draft board interface and can retool the itinerary.

To handle payments on the interface, costs are handled differently per category. The categories of stays and activities use a fronting and reimbursement model. A member of the group can choose to front the costs of these categories, and they can mark if other members of the group paid them back. As shown in figure 13, payment states are explicitly shown as pending, pledged, or paid for these categories. Clear delineation of payment states address the request for clear

state indicators to encourage streamlined payment settlement among the group. Since flights are generally individually booked, they simply have a booked or not booked state indicator, working more as a toggle to resolve this category.

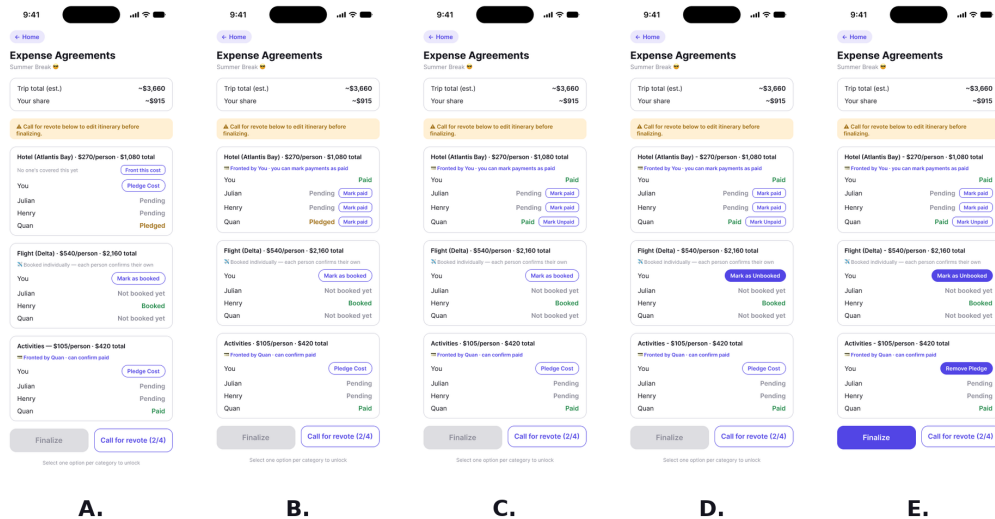


Figure 13—Expense settlement workflow.

10.8 Trip Finalization

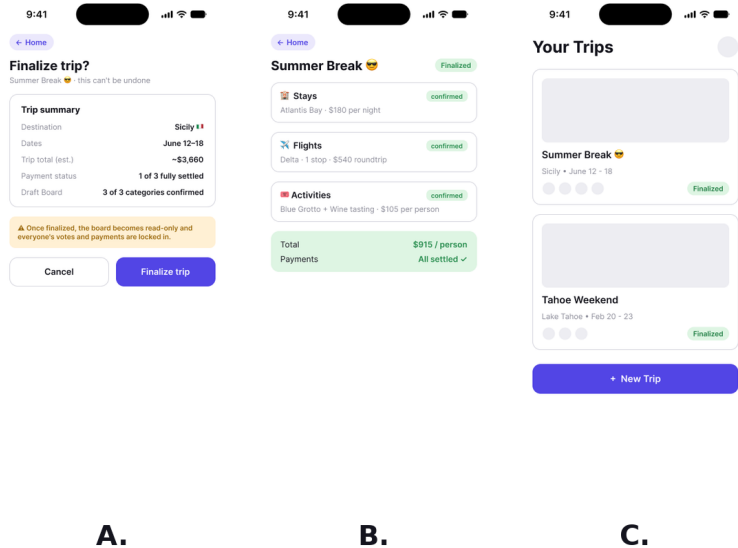


Figure 14—Trip finalization workflow

After each category is settled for the expense agreements interface, the user is then presented with a summary of the decisions that have been made by the group as shown in subfigure A. in figure 14. Once a trip is finalized, a summary of all the details of each category are shown in a simple interface that can be accessed through the finalized trip card.

11 VIDEO PROTOTYPE

The video prototype walks through the high fidelity Figma wireframe designed for this project. The prototype leverages aspects derived from the three medium fidelity design alternatives discussed in the previous section and walks through the workflow of setting up a new group trip, adding group members, voting on preferences and finalizing details on stays, flights, and activities.

The video can be accessed through the following Youtube link: [Video Prototype](#)

12 FINAL EVALUATION PLANNING

12.1 Goal and Participants

The final evaluation assesses whether the high-fidelity combined prototype communicates its workflow clearly and whether participants believe it would be useful for a real group trip. We targeted approximately 20 adult participants through the CS 6750 PeerSurvey system. Participants first watched the video prototype and then completed one brief survey [HERE](#)

12.2 Procedure and Measures

Participants watched the video prototype at

<https://youtu.be/SObAlwuhoTI>. They then answered ten questions. The survey included consent and group-travel background questions, one objective comprehension question asking where tentative hotels, flights, and activities would be found, five fully labeled five-point ratings, and two open-ended questions. The open-ended questions asked what the design did especially well and what should be changed, added, or clarified. The complete survey is provided in Appendix H.

12.3 Analysis Plan

The comprehension item will be summarized using the number and percentage of correct responses. For each five-point item, we will report the median, in-

terquartile range, response distribution, and percentage of participants choosing a positive response (4 or 5). Because the final evaluation examines one design without a comparison condition, descriptive statistics are more appropriate than an inferential comparison test. The two open ended questions will be reviewed thematically. Blank responses and entries such as “N/A” or “nothing” will be treated as non-substantive.

13 FINAL EVALUATION RESULTS

13.1 Participants and Execution

We received 21 complete responses. All participants consented and confirmed that they watched the video prototype. Every participant had prior experience planning a trip involving at least three people: nine (42.9%) had served as a main organizer, nine (42.9%) had shared planning responsibilities, and three (14.3%) had mainly participated in a trip organized by someone else.

The final evaluation was completed as planned using one video-based PeerSurvey questionnaire.

13.2 Quantitative Results

Twelve of 21 participants (57.1%) correctly identified the Draft Board as the location for hotels, flights, and activities that were still being considered. Three selected the Finalized screen, four selected “I am not sure,” one selected Your Trips, and one selected Payments. This result indicates that the conceptual distinction between draft and final information was not always sufficient for participants to recall the exact location of tentative options.

Table 2—Final prototype ratings reported as median [first quartile, third quartile]. Positive responses are ratings of 4 or 5.

Measure	Median [IQR]	Positive n	Positive %
Overall workflow clarity	4 [4, 4]	17	81.0%
Understanding the next action	4 [4, 4]	19	90.5%
Confidence needs are represented	4 [3, 4]	15	71.4%
Draft versus Finalized clarity	4 [4, 4]	19	90.5%
Overall usefulness	4 [3, 4]	15	71.4%

All 5 measures had a median of 4. 17 participants (81.0%) rated the overall workflow Easy or Very easy. 19 (90.5%) gave a positive rating for understanding the

next action, and the same number positively rated the distinction between options still under consideration and the finalized plan. 15 participants (71.4%) were Very or Extremely confident that member preferences, budgets, and constraints were represented. 15 also rated the design Very or extremely useful; 5 rated it Moderately useful, and 1 rated it Slightly useful.

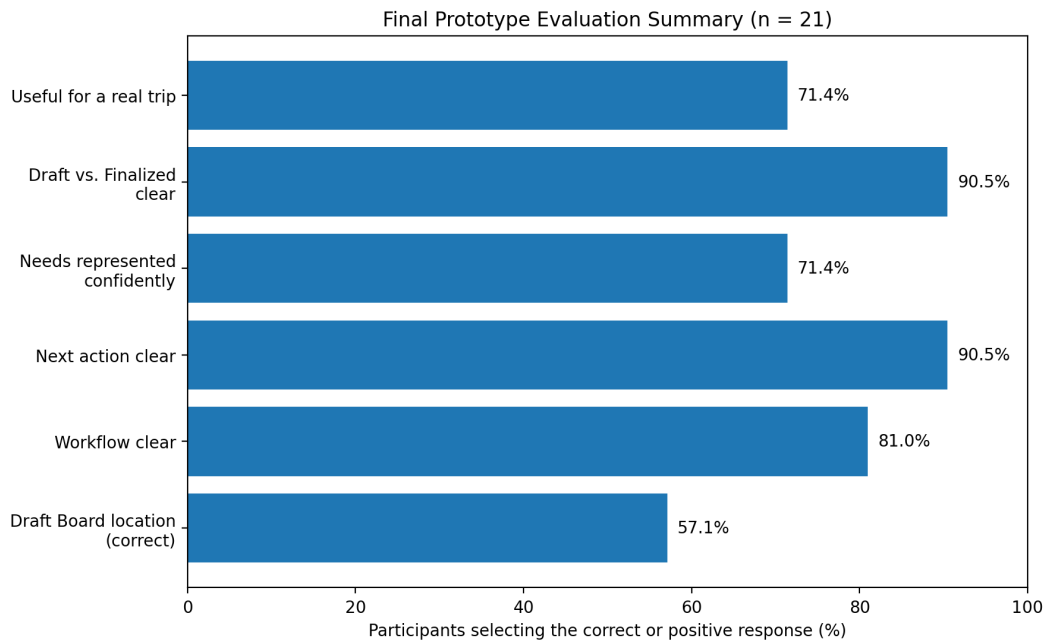


Figure 15—Comprehension and positive rating percentages in the final evaluation (n = 21)

Although 90.5% of participants felt that Draft and Finalized information was easy to distinguish, only 57.1% correctly identified the Draft Board in the specific comprehension question. Participants may have understood the general concept while not retaining the exact screen location from the video. The Draft Board label or navigation path should therefore be strengthened in a future version.

13.3 Qualitative Results

19 participants provided substantive comments about what the prototype did well. The most common theme was "centralization and a single source of truth". Nine responses explicitly praised the overview, the ability to keep requirements and travel details in one place, or the replacement of scattered chat messages with the Draft Board. Four of these also specifically praised the separation be-

tween draft and finalized information. A second theme was "collaborative and asynchronous decision making". 7 responses valued voting, making group opinions visible, or allowing decisions without long message threads. 6 responses described the interface as simple, clean, familiar, or lower in cognitive load. Participants compared the organization to a familiar travel application and stated that the final shared view increased confidence in the agreed plan.

Ten participants provided substantive improvement requests, while 11 indicated that they would make no change or provided no actionable comment. The most repeated request was for "clearer accountability and pending-action cues". Four comments asked for more visible ownership, reminders, deadlines, reviewed/approved status, or a compact summary of unresolved votes, payments, and booking tasks.

13.4 Interpretation

The final evaluation supports the combined direction. Participants most consistently valued the central workspace, visible group voting, and clear Draft-to-Final structure, which were the main reasons for selecting TripOD as the architectural foundation. The positive ratings for next-action clarity and Draft-versus-Finalized clarity suggest that the high-fidelity step by-step flow improved on the information overload reported for the initial TripOD prototype.

The results also identify a clear next revision. The interface should make the Draft Board easier to locate without relying on a guided video, and it should surface ownership, reminders, deadlines, and unresolved actions more clearly.

14 REFERENCES

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- [2] Hutchins, Edwin (1995). "How a Cockpit Remembers Its Speeds". In: *Cognitive Science* 19.3, pp. 265–288.
- [3] Norman, Don (2013). *The design of everyday things: Revised and expanded edition*. Basic books.

A NEEDFINDING SURVEY INSTRUMENT

The following survey was distributed to participants via the CS 6750 PeerSurvey platform. The survey was prefaced with the following introduction:

Coordinating a group trip is a hassle and there is no clear cut solution for it. This survey aims to identify pain points in group travel planning and determine potential opportunities for improvement.

Q1. How often do you travel?

- Never
- 1–2 times per year
- 3–5 times per year
- Over 6 times per year

Q2. What mode of travel do you typically use?

- Flying
- Driving
- Train
- Other

Q3. When you travel, how often is it with a group of 3 or larger? (friends, family, etc.)

[1 = Never, 5 = Always]

Q4. In your most recent group trip, how many people were involved?

- 2–3 people
- 4–6 people
- 7 or more people
- I have not been on a group trip recently

Q5. Who generally takes the lead in organizing a group trip you are involved in?

- Me
- Someone else
- Distributed effort among the group

Q6. What tools or methods do you use to plan and coordinate the group trip?

(Select all that apply)

- Group Text / Instant Messaging
- Email
- Shared Spreadsheet (e.g., Google Sheets)
- Video Call (e.g., Zoom, FaceTime)

- In Person Meeting
 - Travel Agent
 - Other
- Q7.** If you selected “Other” above, please describe the tool or method below.
[Open text]
- Q8.** How many platforms do you typically engage with to coordinate planning for a group trip?
- One primary platform
 - A couple platforms
 - Many different platforms
- Q9.** How would you describe your typical group travel planning style?
- Not organized (Very go with the flow)
 - Somewhat Organized
 - Very organized (Well defined structure and planning steps)
- Q10.** What is the most frustrating part of planning a group trip for you? [Open text]
- Q11.** Have you ever had trouble confirming agreements with certain plans from other members of the group? [1 = Never, 5 = Always]
- Q12.** Have you ever had trouble splitting or collecting costs for a group trip? [1 = Never, 5 = Always]
- Q13.** How stressful is travel planning in a group setting compared to solo travel?
- Much Less Stressful
 - Less Stressful
 - Stressful (About the same)
 - More Stressful
 - Much More Stressful
- Q14.** If you have ever had an experience where group travel planning went poorly, please explain if you are open to sharing. [Open text, optional]
- Q15.** Is there anything about group trip coordination that you wish current tools did or considered? [Open text, optional]
- Q16.** Would you be interested in participating in follow-up needfinding exercises for this project? If yes, please enter your email below. [Open text, optional]

B NEEDFINDING SURVEY RESULTS

ID	Q1	Q2	Q4	Q5	Q8	Q9
1	3-5	Flying	4-6	Someone else	Many	Not organized
2	1-2	Driving	4-6	Distributed	A couple	Not organized
3	3-5	Flying	4-6	Someone else	One primary	Very organized
4	1-2	Flying	2-3	Distributed	A couple	Very organized
5	1-2	Driving	4-6	Distributed	A couple	Somewhat org.
6	3-5	Flying	4-6	Someone else	A couple	Somewhat org.
7	6+	Flying	7+	Me	A couple	Somewhat org.
8	1-2	Flying	2-3	Distributed	A couple	Very organized
9	1-2	Driving	4-6	Distributed	A couple	Somewhat org.
10	3-5	Flying	2-3	Someone else	Many	Very organized
11	3-5	Flying	2-3	Me	A couple	Somewhat org.
12	3-5	Flying	2-3	Distributed	Many	Somewhat org.
13	3-5	Driving	4-6	Someone else	One primary	Somewhat org.
14	6+	Flying	4-6	Distributed	A couple	Somewhat org.
15	1-2	Driving	N/A recently	Someone else	A couple	Somewhat org.
16	1-2	Flying	4-6	Distributed	One primary	Somewhat org.
17	3-5	Driving	4-6	Distributed	One primary	Somewhat org.
18	6+	Driving	4-6	Someone else	A couple	Somewhat org.
19	3-5	Driving	2-3	Distributed	A couple	Somewhat org.
20	6+	Flying	2-3	Me	A couple	Somewhat org.
21	3-5	Train	4-6	Someone else	A couple	Somewhat org.

Table 3—Raw background and behavior need finding survey results (N = 21).

For the following questions, the response options are mapped to quantitative values of 1-5.

ID	Q ₃	Q ₁₁	Q ₁₂	Q ₁₃
1	4	3	3	3
2	3	5	4	5
3	4	2	2	4
4	2	3	3	2
5	5	3	1	4
6	3	3	3	3
7	4	3	2	2
8	1	3	2	2
9	3	3	3	4
10	5	3	1	4
11	3	3	3	3
12	3	3	2	5
13	3	4	4	4
14	4	3	1	3
15	4	3	3	2
16	3	2	2	2
17	3	4	3	4
18	3	5	5	4
19	3	4	3	4
20	3	5	2	3
21	5	4	3	1

Table 4—Raw quantitative friction ratings, need finding survey results (N = 21).

Tools Used for Group Travel Planning (Q6)

Question 6 is multiple response, therefore the answers are compiled in the following table.

Tool or Method	Respondents
Group Text/Instant messaging	21
Video Call	13
In Person Meeting	12
Shared Spreadsheet	10
Email	6
Other	3
Travel Agent	2

Table 5—Coordination tools and methods used, need finding survey (N = 21).

Free Responses Valid free response survey answers compiled below.

- P1. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Communicate with others
- P2. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): People flaking last minute (common issue with people in their 20s)
- Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): Trip to Murfreesboro. Had everything booked only for people to back out last minute.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): I wish there was a way to easily visualize predicted cost as you plan and add on different activities
- P3. • Q7 (*other tool/method*): Social media
- Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Coordinating times for certain activities and events.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): If each activity fits each person's interests
- P4. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): making an optimized routes
- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): all-in-one application, centralized
- P5. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Often times, the correct way to plan a trip itinerary is only clear when you're practically on location, as constraints may not be obvious in advance.
- Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): Usually when my group(s) have an issue, it's because 1-2 people flake last minute or don't want to participate in an activity, so the group splits.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): I don't use any specialized tools apart from online information sources (TripAdvisor, etc.) - my main wish there is for more complete/up-to-date information.
- P6. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): The process of deciding where to go and making sure everyone would be happy
- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Something that manages end to end travel
- P7. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Coordinating when everyone arrives to the destination
- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Easy way to buy everything at once and then split the costs
- P8. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Working with everyone's preferences
- P9. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): The most frustrating part is getting everyone to agree on dates, budget, and activities in a timely way.
- Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): A past trip became stressful because people delayed confirming plans, which made booking flights and lodging more expensive.

- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): I wish there was one shared place to track dates, votes, budget, bookings, payments, and final decisions.
- P10. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Coordinating dates.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Matching up available times for travel and while on vacation together
- P11. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Having too many or no opinions and no one making a decision.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Automatic expense splitting and reminders
- P12. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Accommodating everyone
 - Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): Yes, planning a travel event with 8 people can be tough especially if they all come from different financial backgrounds and ideas of fun. Young adults who don't make money typically stay in more and also more young adults would rather stay in than go out and explore new places.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Yes, I wish there was a travel app for group travel that helped split decisions easier
- P13. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): working with everyone's schedules
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): finding everyone's availability.
- P15. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): When there is no consensus among the group. It is hard to decide on destinations or activities just based on face value of search results without everyone being aligned.
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): If there was a one-stop app where you can add all the trip details with built-in polls and consensus tools for the group to vote on options, that would be very helpful for coordination.
- P16. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): interest conflicts
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): visual interest map or something that is centralized so it minimizes disagreements
- P17. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Getting coordinated with everyone's schedule
 - Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): Some people in the party failed to respond and even pay after the trip
 - Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Ease of use, not bloatware
- P18. • Q10 (*most frustrating part*): People going off the travel plans (booking separate flight, leaving for car trip late, etc)
 - Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): One member of the group once booked a flight for 2 days after the rest of the group. Getting their flight changed was a hassle.

- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Easier bulk booking of hotel/flight plans for small groups of adults
- P19. • Q7 (*other tool/method*): A shared notes document
- Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Coordinating schedules
- Q14 (*bad experience, if shared*): Most trouble I've had is with coordinating schedules
- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): It would be nice to have a more mobile-friendly spreadsheet where you could have a spreadsheet and checklist in the same document
- P20. • Q7 (*other tool/method*): AI such as Claude or chat gpt
- Q10 (*most frustrating part*): Slow reply's or not much feedback
- Q15 (*wish list for tools*): Not that I can think of right now

C SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEW GUIDE AND NOTES

Interview Guide

Interviews followed a semi-structured format. The questions below served as a guide. Interviewers were encouraged to follow participant responses with natural follow-up probes as opposed to adhering rigidly to the script. All interviews were conducted over video call or in person and lasted approximately 20–30 minutes.

1. Tell me about a recent group trip you organized or participated in. Walk me through how the planning started and how it progressed.
2. What tools or methods did you use to coordinate? Why those tools specifically?
3. At what point in the planning did things go smoothly? What made that work? What features did you appreciate about it?
4. Where did things break down or feel frustrating? Can you describe a specific moment? What features made you feel that way?
5. How was the financial side handled, such as the deposits, up-front costs, and reimbursement? Did that cause any tension? Were certain members hesitant to pay after the trip?
6. Was there a point where the group needed to make a firm decision and struggled to do so? What happened? What was the end result?
7. During the planning process, how did you know what was finalized versus still being discussed by the group? Was that ever unclear to you or to anyone

in the group?

8. If you could redesign the planning process from scratch, what would it look like? All ideas are welcome.

Interview Notes

The following are summarized notes from each of the five interviews conducted. Direct quotations are reproduced verbatim where available. Some quotes are lightly modified for grammar purposes, but only minimally so in order to maintain integrity of the quote.

Participant 1 (P1)

Background: Female, 27, marketing coordinator. Primary organizer of a bachelorette trip to Nashville with 8 participants.

Duration: 26 minutes. Conducted over video call.

Tools used: iMessage group chat, Google Docs (shared itinerary), Venmo.

What worked: The initial excitement in the group chat made it easy to collect rough preferences (dates, general vibe). Everyone had strong opinions early on. Lots of suggestions were thrown around in the chat until everyone voted on it, which narrowed it down to two locations/itineraries.

What broke down: As the planning got more specific, the group chat became unmanageable. P1 put together a Google Doc with proposed options for the Airbnb, dinner reservations, and activities. Some group members updated it, but many others ignored it. By mid-planning, P1 was unsure which version of the Google Doc reflected current reality, especially with so many new edits. At one point, two members believed different restaurants had been "confirmed" because one had read P1's message as a finalized plan, while P1 intended it as a suggestion. The confusion was only discovered the day before the trip when P1 sent a final itinerary and one member replied asking why her restaurant choice was different. This confusion was caused by a lack of a common operating picture,

Financial: P1 paid \$1,800 for the Airbnb upfront as the deposit. She sent Venmo requests to seven people. Three paid promptly. The remaining four took between one and four months to reimburse. P1 sent increasingly direct messages and eventually told the group that she would not cover any more deposits unless everyone settles the Airbnb bill.

"I sent the Venmo request three times. The third time I just said: 'I need this by Friday or I'm not covering any of the other deposits.' That's not how I want to talk to my friends at all, but I also had \$1,800 of my own money sitting out there. It's not fair for me to cover everything upfront with no guarantee that my friends will pay me back."

Decision moment: Choosing a dinner reservation for 8 people on a Saturday night. The group discussed it for approximately a week via group chat. Each suggestion generated a new round of replies, emoji reactions, and counter-proposals. P1 eventually made a unilateral decision for the booking and told the group after the fact.

"I just picked one and said we were going. At that point it didn't matter which restaurant. I needed it to be over. Too many ideas, and no one is willing to contribute to a final solution when its such a large group, probably because they are afraid to step on anyone else's toes"

Ideal experience: Something where you can share options and people vote with a simple yes/no. Payments should happen before the trip, not after. She would rather have everyone commit money upfront so she is not carrying the risk of not being paid back until much, much later.

Participant 2 (P2)

Background: Male, 31, software engineer. Participant in a distributed-role trip to Portugal and Spain with 5 friends.

Duration: 22 minutes. Conducted in person.

Tools used: WhatsApp group, Google Sheets (shared cost tracker), individual bookings on Booking.com and Google Flights.

What worked: Individual research. Each member researched one or two cities on their own and reported back to the group. This avoided duplication of effort, and all members felt a greater sense of ownership of the planning process and trip as a whole.

What broke down: A hotel link shared in WhatsApp expired before anyone booked it. One group member had saved a screenshot of the booking page to share later. By the time he shared it, the screenshot showed a different price than

what was now listed live. Two days of back-and-forth followed about whether anyone had actually booked the hotel, what the current price was, and whether it was still available. Nobody knew the authoritative status of the booking. This caused a lot of delays in the booking of the accommodation

"It was a two-day period where we genuinely didn't know if we had a place to stay. Five adults, and none of us could tell you whether the hotel was booked or not."

Financial: Costs were split relatively cleanly using a shared spreadsheet. The larger tension was around a restaurant tasting menu one member wanted to do that others felt was over budget. The discussion revealed that the **group had different unspoken assumptions about the trip's overall budget level.**

Decision moment: A day trip to Sintra. Six days of WhatsApp discussion. Nobody wanted to book without group buy-in; nobody wanted to push too hard and be seen as domineering.

"Eventually someone just wrote 'I'm booking it' and everyone said 'finally.' But it shouldn't require one person to just force a decision. Someone has to fall on the sword every time."

Participant 3 (P3)

Background: Female, 46, high school teacher. Primary organizer of a family beach house trip with 11 participants spanning three generations.

Duration: 29 minutes. Conducted over video call.

Tools used: Facebook Messenger group, email, printed itinerary shared by mail. Some older family members (2) did not use smartphones.

What worked: Once the beach house was decided, logistics within the house organized themselves quite naturally in person. Deciding where to eat, grocery runs, and activities were all very smooth.

What broke down: Information reach was uneven. P3 communicated updates to some family members via Messenger, others via email, and two elderly relative via phone. As a result, family members had different understandings of what was actually finalized.

Financial: The most sensitive aspect of the trip. The originally proposed beach

house cost approximately \$450 per family unit. Two family members quietly told P3 they could not afford that amount. P3 allowed them to have separate, lower contributions from those members privately rather than surfacing the budget disparity in the group, covering the gap herself upfront. P3 then allowed those family members to pay her back over time. This added a lot of financial stress on her.

"You can't put that conversation in a family group chat. But I also can't just pretend the cost is the same for everyone when it isn't. When I take the cost upfront, it adds stress because now I have to follow up with them every month if they don't pay me back on time."

Decision moment: Selecting the beach house itself. The group looked at eight options over three weeks. The ambiguity about what "everyone agreeing" looked like in a family of 11 across different communication channels delayed the decision significantly. P3 eventually made the call and announced it as final.

Ideal experience: Something simpler than what she currently uses and accessible to non-tech-savvy family members. She specifically wanted a tool that could show "here is what we are doing, and this is what has been finalized so far" clearly, so that there is no ambiguity about the status of any item.

Participant 4 (P4)

Background: Male, 28, financial analyst. De-facto organizer of a bachelor party trip to Las Vegas with 6 participants.

Duration: 24 minutes. Conducted in person.

Tools used: iMessage group chat, Venmo, direct booking sites for shows and restaurants.

What worked: Enthusiasm and commitment within the group were high. Everyone genuinely wanted to go and generally agreed on the overall vision for the trip.

What broke down: The execution layer was chaotic. One member booked a show from a screenshot P4 had sent two weeks earlier; the screenshot showed a different show than the one the group had since agreed on. By the time anyone noticed, the wrong show was booked and only partially refundable.

"the group chat is where good ideas go to die. You send something, people react with a thumbs up, and then three weeks later someone acts on the wrong version of the plan and you're arguing about refund policies. Hard to blame anyone though. No one really followed up."

Financial: One member put approximately \$3,000 on a credit card to cover upfront deposits for shows and hotel room blocks, intending to collect reimbursement afterward via Venmo. Eight months after the trip, two members had still not paid their share, due to all of them living in separate parts of the U.S. (active-duty military).

"He stopped asking because it got awkward. But that's \$600 he's just absorbing from his friends. We all know it happened. Nobody talks about it. He's still waiting for payment..."

Decision moment: Saturday night dinner. The group exchanged more than 200 messages over four days debating price point, cuisine, and vibe. No decision was reached before the trip, which meant they arrived in Las Vegas without a reservation and ate at the first restaurant that could seat them.

"If I had to name one thing I'd fix about planning group trips, it's that moment. The endless back-and-forth that ends in nothing. You need something that says: it's been three days, here are the two leading options, everyone vote by tonight, if you don't vote, too bad."

Ideal experience: A built-in decision deadline. Something that converts prolonged discussion into a forced vote after a period of inactivity or at a set time. Also wants **upfront payment collection** rather than post-trip reimbursement.

Participant 5 (P5)

Background: Female, 33, product manager. Participant in a professional team offsite to Austin with 9 colleagues. Planning responsibilities were shared across the team.

Duration: 21 minutes. Conducted over video call.

Tools used: Slack (team communication), Notion (shared planning doc), Zoom (planning calls), individual flight booking via Concur.

What worked: The Notion page kept a relatively structured record of options

under consideration and gave the team a shared starting point. Slack was a good place to drop ideas and have friends vote by reacting to a message.

What broke down: Despite better-than-average tooling, the core problem persisted: nobody could agree on what "finalized" meant versus "we are leaning toward XYZ."

Financial: The company had a budget per person, but the allocation across different cost categories was unclear. A disagreement emerged mid-planning about whether a team dinner at an upscale restaurant fit within the per-person budget or required individual out-of-pocket contribution. Nobody wanted to be the one to say the restaurant was too expensive.

Decision moment: Choosing the hotel. The team had three strong options. In the absence of a clear decision-maker.

"In a work context, nobody wants to be the person who picked the hotel everyone hated. So everyone gives vague positive feedback on every option and nothing moves forward."

Ideal experience: A tool where items move through explicit stages: under review, decision pending, confirmed. Also wants a way for individuals to privately indicate a maximum budget before options are surfaced to the group, so that budget constraints are accounted for without anyone having to publicly disclose what they can or cannot afford.

D RAW BRAINSTORMING NOTES

The following are the individual brainstorming submissions collected during Phase 1 of the brainstorming process, reproduced as submitted before any group evaluation or filtering. Ideas are organized by team member.

Austin Aguilar

1. **Swipe-to-Vote Itinerary Builder.** Use an LLM to generate candidate itineraries based on individual preference inputs, then let group members swipe right or left on each option like a dating app. The most-voted itinerary advances to a finalization step.
2. **AI Trip Assistant.** A conversational agent embedded in the planning app that can answer questions like "what's the cheapest hotel in the city we chose?"

and proactively surface decisions the group hasn't made yet.

3. **Group Preference Matching.** Each member fills out a short preference form (budget, vibe, must-do activities, dietary restrictions) before the group starts deciding. The tool highlights which preferences overlap and flags conflicts before they become arguments.
4. **Trip Inspiration Feed.** A shared feed of destinations, hotels, and activities curated by the app based on the group's combined preferences, replacing the current pattern of individuals sharing random links into a chat.
5. **Booking Confirmation Tracker.** A simple checklist visible to all members showing which bookings have been made and who holds the reservation, directly addressing the "did anyone actually book this?" problem.

Ryan Rim

1. **Draft vs. Finalized Board.** Two separate views within a centralized workspace: a Draft board for everything proposed and under consideration, and a Finalized board for items the group has explicitly approved and locked in. Moving an item from Draft to Finalized requires a structured group action.
2. **Centralized Trip Dashboard.** One shared interface that organizes flights, lodging, and activities in dedicated sections, so that the group has a single place to look rather than scrolling through a chat thread.
3. **Payment Pledge System.** Instead of one person paying upfront and chasing others for reimbursement afterward, each group member commits (pledges) their share before a booking is made. The booking only proceeds once all pledges are collected.
4. **Re-vote Trigger.** If someone wants to revisit a finalized decision, a formal re-vote is required rather than just editing the shared doc. This makes the change visible and deliberate rather than silent.
5. **Cost-Per-Person Preview.** Every option on the board shows an estimated per-person cost automatically, so the group is always comparing apples to apples rather than discussing a total price that means different things to different members.

Henry Chan

1. **Role-Based Planning.** Assign each planning category (destination, lodging, flights, activities, food) to a specific group member. That member researches and proposes options; the rest of the group votes to approve or reject. If

rejected, the assigned member revises based on feedback.

2. **Planning Progress Bar.** A visual indicator showing which categories have been finalized and which are still open, so all members can see at a glance how close the group is to having a complete plan.
3. **Anonymous Preference Input.** Allow members to submit budget ranges, must-haves, and deal-breakers anonymously before options are surfaced, so that no one feels social pressure to match the group's apparent consensus before expressing their real preferences.
4. **Approval/Rejection with Required Reason.** When a member disapproves of a proposed option, the interface requires them to provide a brief reason. This prevents silent vetoes and gives the proposer actionable feedback for a revised proposal.
5. **Flexible Category Assignment.** Allow category assignments to be swapped or shared if a member cannot complete their assigned research on time, with the reassignment visible to the whole group.

Quan Quy

1. **Built-in Polling.** A simple poll feature inside the trip workspace where members vote on options with a thumbs up or thumbs down. No external tools needed.
2. **Decision Deadline.** If a group vote stalls for more than a set number of days, the app automatically locks in the leading option or prompts the group to restart the vote.
3. **Shared Budget Cap.** Each member privately sets a maximum budget. The app only surfaces options that fall within everyone's range, avoiding awkward conversations about cost.
4. **Trip Summary Card.** Once a trip is finalized, the app generates a single shareable summary card with all key details: dates, lodging, flights, and who owes what.
5. **Notification Digest.** Instead of pinging members for every update, the app sends one daily summary of what changed, what's been decided, and what still needs a vote.

Julian Chang

1. **Status Labels on Every Item.** Every proposed option is tagged with a visible status: Proposed, Under Discussion, or Confirmed. No one has to guess

whether something is settled.

2. **Centralized Link Storage.** Instead of sharing links in a chat where they get buried, members paste links directly into the trip board where they stay organized by category.
3. **Upfront Payment Commitment.** Members confirm their share before a booking is made rather than after. Anyone who hasn't committed is flagged before the group proceeds.
4. **Change Log.** A simple history of what was changed, when, and by whom, so no one is confused about why the hotel or restaurant choice looks different from what they remember.
5. **One-Click to Finalize.** Once a majority approves an option, any member can tap a single button to move it to the finalized plan, with all members notified automatically.

E INITIAL EVALUATION SURVEY INSTRUMENT

The initial evaluation is distributed as one fixed-order PeerSurvey questionnaire. All participants review Prototype A (TripSwipe), followed by Prototype B (TripOD), and then Prototype C (TripRoles).

E.1 Participant Background

- Q1.** I confirm that I voluntarily agree to participate in this study. If you select No, please exit without submitting.
- Yes, I agree to participate
 - No, I do not agree to participate (please exit without submitting)
- Q2.** Have you ever participated in planning a leisure trip involving at least three people?
- Yes, and I was one of the main organizers
 - Yes, and planning responsibilities were shared
 - Yes, but someone else handled most of the planning
 - No, I have not participated in planning a group trip
- Q3.** When planning group travel, which role best describes you?
- I usually lead most of the planning
 - I share planning responsibilities with others
 - I mainly provide preferences or feedback
 - I usually follow plans made by someone else
 - I do not have enough experience to say

- Other
- Q4.** How recently have you participated in planning a group trip?
- Within the past 6 months
 - 6–12 months ago
 - 1–2 years ago
 - More than 2 years ago
 - I have never participated in planning a group trip
- Q5.** What device are you mainly using to complete this survey?
- Smartphone
 - Tablet
 - Laptop
 - Desktop computer
 - Other

E.2 Prototype A: TripSwipe

Shared scenario: Imagine that you are one of five friends planning a four-day leisure trip. The group needs to collect preferences, compare plans, agree on one option, and understand what is finalized and what still needs attention. Review Screens A–C across the top row, then Screens D–E across the bottom row.

- A1.** Which statement best describes Prototype A's main approach to group travel planning?
- One organizer manually creates the complete itinerary without receiving group input
 - Each traveler submits preferences, reviews generated itinerary options, and votes on the options
 - Travelers use a free-form group chat to plan the trip
 - The interface only tracks payments after a trip has been booked
- A2.** Based on the final screen, what still needs to happen before the trip is fully confirmed?
- Additional group members need to confirm the itinerary, or the group may request another vote
 - The organizer must create a new destination
 - Every traveler must upload identification
 - Nothing remains—the trip is already fully confirmed
 - I am not sure

- A3.** How easy or difficult was it to understand the current planning state of the trip? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- A4.** How easy or difficult would it be to contribute your own preferences using this design? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- A5.** How easy or difficult was it to understand what you or the group should do next? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- A6.** How confident would you feel that this design represents the preferences and constraints of all group members? *[1 = Not at all confident, 5 = Extremely confident]*
- A7.** How fair or unfair does the group decision process in this prototype appear? *[1 = Very unfair, 5 = Very fair]*
- A8.** How useful would this prototype be for planning an actual group trip? *[1 = Not at all useful, 5 = Extremely useful]*
- A9.** What did you like most about Prototype A, and what is one thing you would change, remove, or add? *[Open text]*

E.3 Prototype B: TripOD

Continue with the same shared scenario. Review Screens A–C across the top row, D–F across the middle row, and G–H across the bottom row. This concept uses destination voting, a shared draft board for stays, flights, and activities, group payment tracking, and a finalization step.

- B1.** Which statement best describes Prototype B's main approach to group travel planning?
- It provides a shared workspace that separates tentative options from the finalized trip plan
 - It automatically creates itineraries and asks users to swipe on each one
 - It allows only one organizer to view or edit the trip
 - It is mainly a messaging application with no planning structure
- B2.** Which feature is primarily intended to prevent tentative options from being confused with confirmed plans?
- Separate Draft and Finalized views
 - Member profile initials
 - A trip cover image
 - The New Trip button
 - I am not sure
- B3.** How easy or difficult was it to understand the current planning state of the

- trip? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- B4.** How easy or difficult would it be to contribute your own preferences or proposed options using this design? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- B5.** How easy or difficult was it to understand what you or the group should do next? *[1 = Very difficult, 5 = Very easy]*
- B6.** How confident would you feel that this design represents the preferences, financial commitments, and constraints of all group members? *[1 = Not at all confident, 5 = Extremely confident]*
- B7.** How fair or unfair does the group decision process in this prototype appear? *[1 = Very unfair, 5 = Very fair]*
- B8.** How useful would this prototype be for planning an actual group trip? *[1 = Not at all useful, 5 = Extremely useful]*
- B9.** What did you like most about Prototype B, and what is one thing you would change, remove, or add? *[Open text]*

E.4 Prototype C: TripRoles

Continue with the same shared scenario. Review Screens A–D in order. This concept assigns planning categories such as hotels and food to group members, shows completion progress, and lets members approve or disapprove proposed options.

- C1.** Which statement best describes Prototype C's main approach to group travel planning?
- It assigns planning categories to group members and lets the group vote on proposed options
 - It generates complete itineraries and asks travelers to swipe on them
 - It only tracks reimbursements after the trip
 - It provides an unstructured group chat
 - I am not sure
- C2.** On the voting screen, a hotel option shows 0 Approve and 3 Disapprove. What does this indicate?
- Three members disapprove of the option and no members approve of it
 - The hotel has already been booked for three people
 - Three members have completed payment
 - The option automatically becomes the final choice
 - I am not sure
- C3.** How easy or difficult was it to understand the current planning state of the

- trip? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- C4.** How easy or difficult would it be to contribute your own preference or decision using this design? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- C5.** How easy or difficult was it to understand what you or the group should do next? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- C6.** How confident would you feel that this design represents the preferences and constraints of all group members? [1 = *Not at all confident*, 5 = *Extremely confident*]
- C7.** How fair or unfair does the group decision process in this prototype appear? [1 = *Very unfair*, 5 = *Very fair*]
- C8.** How useful would this prototype be for planning an actual group trip? [1 = *Not at all useful*, 5 = *Extremely useful*]
- C9.** What did you like most about Prototype C, and what is one thing you would change, remove, or add? [Open text]

E.5 Final Comparison

- F1a.** First choice: select the prototype you would most prefer to use. Do not repeat a prototype across F1a–F1c.
- Prototype A: TripSwipe
 - Prototype B: TripOD
 - Prototype C: TripRoles
- F1b.** Second choice: select the prototype you would next prefer to use. Do not repeat a prototype across F1a–F1c.
- Prototype A: TripSwipe
 - Prototype B: TripOD
 - Prototype C: TripRoles
- F1c.** Third choice: select the prototype you would least prefer to use. Do not repeat a prototype across F1a–F1c.
- Prototype A: TripSwipe
 - Prototype B: TripOD
 - Prototype C: TripRoles
- F2.** Which prototype should serve as the main foundation for the team’s final design?
- Prototype A: Preference entry and itinerary voting
 - Prototype B: Centralized Draft-to-Final trip workspace
 - Prototype C: TripRoles

F3. Why did you choose that prototype as the best foundation for the final design? *[Open text]*

F4. Which features should be included in the final design? *(Select all that apply)*

- Private entry of each traveler's preferences
- Personal budget range
- Trip vibe or pace preferences
- Automatically generated itinerary options
- Swipe-based voting
- Detailed views of itinerary options
- Final confirmation or re-vote
- A centralized shared trip workspace
- Separate Draft and Finalized views
- Group voting on destinations, hotels, flights, or activities
- Price-change warnings
- Estimated total and per-person cost
- Deposit pledges
- Paid, pledged, and pending payment statuses
- Assigning different planning categories to group members
- Progress indicators for planning tasks
- Category-by-category voting on proposed options
- Approve/disapprove vote counts
- Ability to add new planning categories
- Other (describe in F6)

F5. Is there an important group travel-planning problem that none of the three prototypes handles well? Please explain. *[Open text]*

F6. Do you have any other comments or suggestions for the final prototype?
Thank you for completing our evaluation. *[Open text, optional]*

E.6 Comprehension Answer Key

- A1: Each traveler submits preferences, reviews generated itinerary options, and votes on the options.
- A2: Additional group members need to confirm the itinerary, or the group may request another vote.
- B1: It provides a shared workspace that separates tentative options from the finalized trip plan.
- B2: Separate Draft and Finalized views.

- C1: It assigns planning categories to group members and lets the group vote on proposed options.
- C2: Three members disapprove of the option and no members approve of it.

F INITIAL EVALUATION SURVEY RESPONSE RESULTS

The following sections show the quantitative scores of the initial evaluation survey. Questions are correlated with responses with quantitative values of 1-5, comprehension of the concept is judged by quizzing participants with two questions within the survey, if the amount of questions they get correct are displayed in the comprehension column.

Quantitative Evaluation Matrix — Prototype A (TripSwipe)

ID	Comprehension	A3	A4	A5	A6	A7	A8
1	2/2	4	4	4	4	3	1
2	1/2	4	4	2	3	4	4
3	2/2	4	4	4	4	4	5
4	2/2	5	5	4	4	4	4
5	2/2	3	4	4	3	3	4
6	2/2	4	4	4	2	4	3
7	2/2	4	2	4	3	4	3
8	1/2	1	1	1	1	1	1
9	2/2	3	3	3	2	4	2
10	2/2	3	4	3	2	3	2
11	1/2	3	4	3	3	3	3
12	2/2	4	5	4	3	3	4
13	2/2	4	5	4	3	4	4
14	2/2	4	3	3	2	3	2
15	2/2	3	4	2	2	3	3
16	2/2	4	5	4	3	4	4
17	2/2	4	3	4	5	5	5
18	1/2	5	4	4	4	4	4
19	1/2	4	4	3	3	4	3
20	1/2	3	3	3	3	3	3
21	2/2	4	5	5	4	5	5

Table 6—Raw quantitative evaluation data — Prototype A / TripSwipe (N = 21)

Quantitative Evaluation Matrix — Prototype B (TripOD)

The following table contains the raw Likert-scale ratings (1–5) and comprehension check results for Prototype B across all 21 evaluation participants.

ID	Comprehension	B3	B4	B5	B6	B7	B8
1	1/2	4	4	4	4	4	4
2	1/2	1	4	4	3	3	5
3	2/2	4	4	4	4	4	5
4	2/2	4	3	4	2	3	3
5	1/2	4	3	4	4	4	4
6	2/2	4	4	4	3	3	3
7	2/2	4	4	4	4	5	3
8	2/2	1	1	1	1	1	1
9	2/2	3	3	2	2	3	1
10	2/2	3	3	4	4	3	3
11	1/2	2	3	3	4	3	3
12	2/2	4	4	4	4	4	5
13	2/2	2	3	3	4	3	3
14	2/2	4	4	4	3	4	4
15	2/2	2	2	2	3	3	3
16	2/2	5	4	4	4	4	5
17	2/2	5	5	5	5	5	5
18	2/2	3	3	3	3	3	3
19	2/2	3	4	3	3	4	3
20	0/2	3	3	2	2	3	3
21	2/2	4	4	4	4	4	4

Table 7—Raw quantitative evaluation data — Prototype B / TripOD (N = 21)

Quantitative Evaluation Matrix — Prototype C (TripRoles)

The following table contains the raw Likert-scale ratings (1–5) and comprehension check results for Prototype C across all 21 evaluation participants.

ID	Comprehension	C3	C4	C5	C6	C7	C8
1	2/2	5	5	5	5	4	3
2	0/2	4	2	4	4	3	3
3	2/2	4	4	4	3	4	3
4	2/2	3	3	2	3	4	3
5	2/2	3	3	4	4	4	4
6	2/2	4	4	4	3	4	3
7	2/2	3	2	2	2	3	2
8	2/2	1	1	1	1	1	1
9	2/2	2	3	3	3	4	2
10	2/2	4	4	4	3	3	2
11	2/2	3	3	3	3	4	3
12	2/2	3	4	3	3	3	3
13	2/2	5	4	4	4	4	4
14	2/2	4	5	4	3	4	4
15	2/2	4	3	3	3	4	3
16	2/2	4	4	4	4	4	4
17	2/2	3	4	4	5	5	4
18	2/2	5	5	5	4	5	4
19	2/2	4	4	4	3	3	3
20	0/2	3	2	3	2	3	2
21	2/2	4	2	4	2	2	3

Table 8—Raw quantitative evaluation data — Prototype C / TriRoles (N = 21)

G INITIAL EVALUATION SURVEY FREE RESPONSE RESULTS

A9 — TripSwipe: liked most / one change (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P1. No one will agree on a trip plan.
- P3. Easy to understand, nothing to add.
- P4. Itinerary is spelled completely wrong. Making the votes optionally anonymous or not.
- P5. Everyone has to agree. A toggle for dark mode.
- P6. I'd add the option to help vote on accommodations (outside of itinerary)
- P7. I liked that people could submit preferences, but it would be great if choice-ranked preferences were also included for better nuance
- P9. I would add a location/country filter because I don't want to go to certain locations
- P10. I think that Prototype A has potential but does not map the process of planning

a trip that people naturally gravitate towards. For instance, people in the trip have set a location and date because it fits their desired itinerary or plans and they may have a specific location and time they want to go somewhere. This prototype does not account for specific or “hard” travel plans that must take place and serves as a planner of recommended trips and not the ideal trip.

- P11. I liked that setting my preferences was quick, it reminded me of ordering off a short menu. I’d add a plain sentence to the last panel like ‘3 confirmations left’ instead of a icon list with a percentage.
- P12. I could see myself using this for a quick weekend trip, my main concern is the swipe format flattens everything into a binary like/dislike, so it can’t capture ‘I like this but only if the price drops.’
- P13. Low effort, which is what I need between shifts and chores. I would add a notification for when it’s my turn to act, so I don’t have to keep checking.
- P14. It seems quick and efficient, but there’s no accessibility options, especially for those who may have specific needs, so they would have to research everything anyways.
- P15. Swiping does feel casual, but the 3/4 Submitted bar made me nervous(?) I was holding things up. I’d also want to see the cost BEFORE swiping yes, since budget is an important factor for most people.
- P16. I liked how quick and low-effort the swipe-based preference entry is; I’d add a clearer summary of how the group’s votes produced the chosen itinerary so the outcome feels transparent.
- P17. I like the idea of swiping. That being said the swiping part was not super clear to me from images.
- P18. Add more options
- P19. I liked the suggestion part, similar to an AI-suggestion tool? Maybe I would add onto it or remove it, based on on how well users like it.
- P21. I really like that it feels like everyone’s preferences for the trip are taken into account, and maybe a feature where everyone can select an activity they’d like to prioritize. An activity that they really want to do no matter if all of their other preferences are out voted by the group.

B9 — TripOD: liked most / one change (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P1. Input from non coordinators
- P3. Showing paid and unpaid seemed useful. I wouldn’t change anything.
- P4. It’s a lot easier for the person who is mainly planning to communicate plan

details to the group. Add permission options like maybe not allow certain people to contribute or make changes, just only allow them to view.

- P5. Cost breakdown
- P6. Prototype b had was I said was missing in A
- P7. I like how the prototype focused on the destination and logistics rather than the activities in the first phase. It's to make that stuff separate
- P9. IMO I feel like there are too many features it is trying a show and it is a bit cluttered to look at. I think more simple UI would help users find what they are looking for
- P10. I liked how everything is separated and that each trip has their own items(housing, flights, and other custom fields). One thing I would change is that there is no intuitive way to go back and update or change information. How would payments work if a hotel reservation is canceled? What if there is a last min change of plans and only specific variables change (number of people, payments, items, etc...) This prototype does not seem to encapsualte this and should simplify things, like not managing payments in the app, which seems to require manual input and does not always reflect reality.
- P11. I like how everything like hotels and flights are naturally included, but there were alot of options and buttons that I wasn't sure what would do. Maybe something simpler would be great.
- P12. I like the separate draft/final states, per-person cost breakdown, and payment status. It's basically what my friend group manually put in a spreadsheet + group chat. I'd add alerts on price-changes in itineraries since that's an important thing that change mid-planning
- P13. Its great for an organizer, but too much to read for someone who just checks in occasionally. A summary of what needs my attention would help.
- P14. Closest to what I envisioned the product would look like. Again, accessibility does not seem to be considered.
- P15. Knowing my responsibility is reassuring, but the screen was alot to process at once for sure. A "start here" walkthrough would help someone newer to trip planning.
- P16. Separating draft from finalized plans plus payment tracking is the clearest way to avoid confusion about what's actually booked; I'd add price-change alerts so tentative options don't quietly go stale.
- P17. I liked the voting process. I dont like the idea of adding a new destination suggestion in the middle of voting.

- P18. Too complicated a little bit
- P19. I liked how specific it was and had a clear draft/finalized version of each trip. However, I think it is a little verbose and can be more simple or easier to go through each part of the flow, since it was confusing going to the next slide and understanding what it does.
- P21. I like that it shows the financial aspect of who's paid and who hasn't. It keeps awkward conversations about who has paid and who hasn't down since it's viewable to everyone going. Honestly I just like the way Prototype A presents the information better?

C9 — TripRoles: liked most / one change (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P1. I can see that if individuals are planning individual portions of the trip, they might not make the most convenient decisions
- P3. Voting system was good. Overall I think the other apps would be more useful than this one.
- P4. Adding a summarized/finalized view that reflects what's voted in an organized itinerary.
- P5. Short and simple
- P7. I like the ability to delegate if group members so choose to do that, but like with prototype 1, there's not much nuance to approve and disapprove votes. Also, it's not clear how to proceed if members disapprove. Does the original planner just propose something else for another vote? That might seem slightly inefficient if the planner had to propose a new option for a vote one by one
- P10. I liked its planned structure that a plan has certain items and that a person is responsible for it. I guess the only thing that I'm unsure of is that one person per task may not be reasonable or not fit the structure of a plan all the time, but maybe that can be done in chats and the app can serve more of template for the final plan where popular ideas are saved.
- P11. I liked that everyone has a task so not a specific subgroup of travelers had the majority say. This would be great if I had a "balanced" group of travelers or if everyone had similar/zero preference on the specific itinerary,
- P12. Delegating seems smart in theory, but it depends on everyone actually doing their assigned task on time. Personally, someone always drops the ball, so I'd want a nudge or a fallback if a category owner goes quiet for a period of time.
- P13. I like just voting without owning the whole trip. I'd add an option to say I trust the group, for people who don't want to weigh in on every item.

- P14. I like “owning” a part of the trip and vetting it before a vote happens. I’d add a checklist template per category, like a standard checklist for hotels with an option to add more checks as needed.
- P15. I like not being in charge of anything fully. I also feel like disapprove doesn’t provide much value. Why does the person disapprove? What do they prefer instead? There are many reasons for no, but some of them might be able to narrow the scope and allow the group to have a better trip altogether.
- P16. Assigning categories with progress tracking spreads the work fairly and avoids overloading one organizer; I’d let members swap or share a category if someone can’t finish theirs.
- P17. I liked the task delegation. I did not like the Selected This and Not Selected This label names.
- P18. Good
- P19. I liked how simple it was and that it assigned clear responsibilities to participants. However, this would fail in groups that prefer 1-2 people leading the planning, if the group had many preferences, or if a person who is bad at planning is in charge of an important part of the trip.
- P21. Honestly I think C sets everyone up for a constant back and forth. What if the people voting never approve of what the person tasked with planning said activity chooses.

F3 — Why this prototype as the foundation (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P1. Makes the easiest path to a successful trip rather than a group decision
- P3. It had the most options for planning a trip. Seemed straight forward and not overly complicated.
- P4. I prefer the simplicity of Prototype A. Planning is already stressful, so using an application that reduces that noise is the most usable.
- P5. It has the best cost breakdown for sections. Having more information about hotel and flights are nice.
- P6. I think a mixture between b and c work. I feel the workspace preference might depend on how involved someone wants to be with planning
- P7. Least ambiguous, but if you incorporated ranked choice into prototype A, I think that would be my first choice
- P9. I makes the most sense and has a simple UI to understand
- P10. I think a structured, simple foundation is important (which Prototype C exemplifies best) while keeping options implicitly open for change.

- P11. It was simple, unlike the others that stressed me out a little with their options.
- P12. It tracks money and status in a way that I'd organize for an actual booking.
The other two are also well-designed but lack this factor.
- P13. It lets people participate at the level they have capacity for. That flexibility matters more to me than any one feature.
- P14. It gives the most room to document details before the group votes, so people vote with full information instead of just a photo.
- P15. It felt the least intimidating as someone newer to organizing trips, I would just need my budget set and not feel like I'm slowing the group down.
- P16. The centralized draft-to-final workspace keeps the whole group looking at the same tentative options and what's confirmed, and it can absorb A's voting and C's task assignment on top of that structure.
- P17. It seemed clearest on the entire process.
- P18. Easy to execute
- P19. Simplest and best to serve as a foundation.
- P21. I feel A allows everyone to express their desires for the trip most over the other two options.

F5 — Problems no prototype addressed well (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P1. Not that I can think of
- P4. None of the prototypes account for proportional food-cost splitting. A flat split isn't fair to the rest of the group, so there needs to be a feature that isolates the high-volume eaters and tracks individual consumption so we aren't funding their excess calories
- P5. Covered most the bases.
- P6. I would think I'd you were to use a "finalized view" there would need to be an understanding that sometimes a schedule is followed extremely loosely and it depends on the group
- P7. Capturing the nuance of some preferences. As in, sometimes options aren't simple yes or no matters for people, but just what they'd prefer. Someone might prefer not to do one thing generally, but may be willing to do it if there's compromise
- P10. I don't think they really solve the issue of peoples' true happiness/satisfaction about a plan since it just gathers votes. However, I think that's well out of scope and can be not considered here.
- P11. None really accounted for a simpler mode, maybe something like a technolog-

ical assistance or senior citizens assistance mode would be nice.

- P12. None handle deletion or removal of information. What happens with refunds, mid-trip changes, or holiday-jacked prices?
- P13. None let a member put in downtime or quiet blocks in the itinerary.
- P14. None of the three have a field for accessibility needs, which is obviously not the main concern or driving point of this product but it is something to note.
- P16. None handles hard constraints well - conflicting available dates or a budget ceiling some members can't exceed. Surfacing those conflicts early, before voting, would prevent wasted decisions.
- P17. None.
- P19. I think they all work but don't really handle actual user semantics and behavior as they all felt a bit "off" going from panel to panel.
- P21. Honestly maybe one of the options cover this, but I personally would just hope everyone going on the trip gets to do one activity that they truly want to do. The ability for everyone to prioritize one activity would be the most important feature to add if I didn't miss this feature in the proposed prototypes above.

F6 — Additional comments (n=21, non-substantive omitted)

- P4. Maybe add a penalty system for the freeloaders who contribute nothing to the planning
- P6. Often when planning a trip, might experience is that people might not follow the plans
- P7. Ranked choice voting
- P13. A low-effort mode that only surfaces the decisions that truly need my input would help busy members.
- P14. TLDR: Adding accessibility features would be nice.
- P21. None! Good luck on the project!

H FINAL EVALUATION SURVEY INSTRUMENT

Participants watched the video prototype before completing the following brief survey.

- Q1.** I voluntarily agree to participate in this study. I also watched the video prototype.
- Yes
 - No

- Q2.** Have you participated in planning a trip involving at least three people?
- Yes, as a main organizer
 - Yes, with shared planning
 - Yes, but someone else mainly organized
 - No
- Q3.** Where would you find hotels, flights, or activities that the group is still considering?
- Draft Board
 - Finalized screen
 - Payments screen
 - Your Trips screen
 - I am not sure
- Q4.** How easy was it to understand the overall trip-planning workflow? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- Q5.** How easy was it to understand what you or the group should do next? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- Q6.** How confident are you that the prototype represents each member's preferences, budget, and constraints? [1 = *Not at all confident*, 5 = *Extremely confident*]
- Q7.** How easy was it to distinguish between options still being considered and the finalized trip plan? [1 = *Very difficult*, 5 = *Very easy*]
- Q8.** How useful would this prototype be for planning an actual group trip? [1 = *Not at all useful*, 5 = *Extremely useful*]
- Q9.** What did the final prototype do especially well? [Open text]
- Q10.** What is the most important thing you would change, add, or clarify? [Open text]

I FINAL EVALUATION DETAILED RESULTS

I.1 Participant Background

Table 9—Final evaluation participant experience (n = 21).

Experience	Count	Percent
Main organizer	9	42.9%
Shared planning responsibilities	9	42.9%
Someone else mainly organized	3	14.3%
No group-planning experience	0	0.0%

I.2 Comprehension Responses

Table 10—Responses to the Draft Board comprehension question.

Response	Count	Percent
Draft Board (correct)	12	57.1%
Finalized screen	3	14.3%
I am not sure	4	19.0%
Your Trips screen	1	4.8%
Payments screen	1	4.8%

I.3 Rating Distributions

Table 11—Counts for each five-point final-evaluation measure.

Measure	1	2	3	4	5
Overall workflow clarity	0	0	4	15	2
Understanding the next action	1	1	0	17	2
Confidence needs are represented	0	0	6	14	1
Draft versus Finalized clarity	0	0	2	15	4
Overall usefulness	0	1	5	14	1

I.4 Qualitative Coding Summary

Table 12—Recurring themes in the final evaluation. Themes may overlap within one response.

Theme	Responses	Interpretation
Centralized information / single source of truth	9	Participants valued seeing travel requirements, options, and the agreed plan in one place rather than across scattered chats
Collaborative voting and visible group input	7	Participants valued asynchronous decisions and the visibility of group opinions.
Simple, clean, familiar workflow	6	Participants described the interface as low in clutter, navigable, familiar, or lower in cognitive load
Draft-versus-Finalized separation	4	Participants specifically praised the separation of tentative options from the authoritative plan
Clearer ownership, reminders, and pending actions	4	The most common improvement request was to show who still needs to vote, pay, review, or complete a booking task
Simplification / progressive disclosure	2	Some participants still wanted information reduced or hidden until needed
Other individual requests	—	Requests included large-group scalability, organizer-led planning, clearer shared-booking responsibilities, more option types, and a more travel-specific visual style